

**BUSINESS: Pg 2**  
DOJ seeks dismissal of charges in Adani case



**CITY: Pg 3**  
Delhi calls employees back to office



**NATION: Pg 5**  
CJP urges PM Modi to break 'resounding silence' over its protest



TO DISCUSS RESIGNATIONS, SIT REPORT IN DONATION ROW

# Ram Temple Trust meeting tomorrow

## EXTREMELY PAINED BY DONATIONS THEFT, GUILTY MUST BE PUNISHED: RSS

**BISWAJEET BANERJEE**

**AYODHYA:** The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust will hold a crucial meeting here on July 6 amid the ongoing controversy over the alleged misappropriation of donations at the Ram Temple. The resignations of general secretary Champat Rai and trustee Dr Anil Mishra and the Special Investigation Team's (SIT) interim report are poised to dominate the agenda.

According to a meeting notice issued by trust treasurer Swami Govind Dev Giri, the meeting will begin at 3 pm at Maniram Das Chhawani. Besides considering the resignations of Rai and Mishra, the trust will discuss the SIT's findings on the counting and management of donations received through the temple's donation boxes.

The meeting will also take up future arrangements for temple management and



Police recovered a Maruti Brezza vehicle from Kaushapuri Colony belonging to Avinash Shukla, an accused arrested in the Ram Temple donations alleged theft case, in Ayodhya on Saturday

**CLOSER LOOK**

- » The resignations of general secretary Champat Rai and trustee Dr Anil Mishra and the SIT interim report are poised to dominate the agenda
- » The meeting will also take up future arrangements for temple management and approve the accounts and financial statements for the financial year 2025-26
- » This is the first formal meeting of the trust since allegations of theft and embezzlement of temple donations surfaced

**WE ARE ALL EXTREMELY PAINED AND ANGERED BY THIS EVENT: RSS SECOND-IN-COMMAND SAID IN A STATEMENT ON X**

RSS Sarkaryavah Dattatreya Hosabale, in a statement on Friday, said the "highly condemnable" incident had deeply hurt the sentiments of Ram devotees and asserted that the prevailing "confusion and uncertainty" surrounding the episode must end through corrective measures.

"We are all extremely pained and angered by this event," the RSS second-in-command said in a statement on X. It is the organisation's first response to the alleged theft of funds that has led to the arrest of eight people as well as the resignations of Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust general secretary Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra.

Asserting that "anti-Hindu and anti-national forces" are seeking to malign Hindu dharma by exploiting the "unfortunate incident", Hosabale called on all Hindus to display necessary patience and restraint to thwart such "conspiracies".

Sources said the trust's bylaws do not permit action against any office bearer without first seeking an explanation and following due process. Any proposal to accept resignations or remove office bearers will require approval by the prescribed majority of trustees.

The meeting is also expected to consider names for filling vacant positions in the trust.

Questions remain over who will chair the meeting as trust president Mahant Nritya Gopal Das, who is scheduled to preside over it, is currently admitted to a trauma centre in Lucknow. Though his condition has reportedly improved slightly, it is unclear whether he will attend.

The meeting notice has also attracted attention because it carries no physical or digital signature, despite mentioning that it was issued with the approval of the **Continued on P4**

# India weathered energy storm: PM



PM Narendra Modi, Rajasthan Governor Haribhav Bagde, Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, CM Bhajanlal Sharma and others at the inauguration of the Pachpadra refinery, in Balotra, Rajasthan, on Saturday

*Credits proactive policies, diplomacy*

**MPOST BUREAU**

**PACHPADRA (RAJASTHAN):** India successfully navigated one of the biggest global energy crises of the century through proactive policies, diversified fuel sourcing and strong diplomatic ties, with "minimal burden" on citizens, while major countries struggled, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Saturday.

Some forces were busy spreading fear in public and political games were played, but "they must be wallowing in the depths of despair today", Modi said at a public meeting, asserting that the country's handling of the situation would be remembered as an "unprecedented" chapter in history.

"The war in West Asia created the biggest energy crisis of the 21st century. Many powerful nations struggled with fuel shortages. India overcame this challenge because it took the right decisions at the right time, assessed the situation correctly, used its resources in a balanced manner and utilised its diplomatic strength positively", he said.

Prime Minister Modi, who dedicated the country's first greenfield integrated refinery-cum-petrochemical complex to the nation in Rajasthan's Balotra area, lauded authorities for working tirelessly over the last two months to repair the project, where a major fire had occurred on April 20, forcing the postponement of its scheduled inauguration by the PM the next day.

On Friday, strong winds accompanied by rains damaged banners and hoardings at the refinery site ahead of the prime minister's visit and workers were engaged since Saturday morning for the repairs.

The prime minister said India has substantially expanded its refining capacity while several developed regions have failed to do so.

"The United States has not built a new refinery in the last 50 years. Europe's refining capacity has continuously declined. India has now become the **Continued on P4**

**KEY POINTS**

- » 'The war in West Asia created the biggest energy crisis of the 21st century. Many powerful nations struggled with fuel shortages'
- » 'India overcame this challenge because it took the right decisions at the right time, assessed the situation correctly, used its resources in a balanced manner and utilised its diplomatic strength positively'
- » PM Modi, who dedicated the country's first greenfield integrated refinery-cum-petrochemical complex to the nation in Rajasthan's Balotra area



SP, Congress resorting to negative politics in UP

**BJP chief Nitin Nabin**

In today's paper

...

|                                     |   |
|-------------------------------------|---|
| <b>BUSINESS</b>                     |   |
| INDIA-ISRAEL PACT COMES INTO EFFECT | 2 |
| <b>SPORT</b>                        |   |
| SWIATEK STUNNED AT SW19             | 2 |
| <b>CITY</b>                         |   |
| GYMKHANA STAFF MOVE HC              | 3 |
| <b>NATION</b>                       |   |
| EAM TO EMBARK ON 6-NATION TOUR      | 5 |
| <b>INTERNATIONAL</b>                |   |
| UKRAINE STRIKES ST PETERSBURG       | 6 |

DELHI RIOTS CASE

# Court denies bail to Khalid, Imam

**OUR CORRESPONDENT**

**NEW DELHI:** A court on Saturday rejected the bail applications of student activists Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam in the larger-conspiracy case linked to the 2020 northeast Delhi riots, saying it had "no option but to follow" the Supreme Court's January 5 order and, therefore, could neither entertain the pleas nor grant them the relief.

Additional Sessions Judge Sameer Bajpai said the bail pleas are not even maintainable in the trial court.

The judge said, "This court has no option but to follow the judgment dated January 5, 2026, as passed by the Supreme Court, whereby the petitions of both the applicants were dismissed. Following the said order of the Supreme Court, this court cannot entertain the applications and grant bail to the applicants. In fact, the applications are not maintainable and they are hereby dismissed."

The court said although the applicants had argued that there was a change in circumstances following a division bench judgment of the top court in the case of Syed Ifikhar Andrabi, the issue concerning the divergence of opinion between that verdict and the Supreme Court's judgment in Gulfisha Fatima versus State has already been referred to a larger bench.

"Unless the issue is settled, the court cannot consider the present applications on any ground," the judge said. The court further said it cannot even examine **Continued on P4**



'Can't entertain bail pleas in view of SC order'



**NATION BIDS FAREWELL**

Hundreds of thousands of mourners gather around the flag-draped coffin of Iran's late Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, during the start of a dayslong funeral, in Tehran, on Saturday

AP/PTI

# Rain batters Mumbai: 200 mm in 12 hours

Brace for more today, says IMD

**MUMBAI:** Torrential downpours battered Mumbai on Saturday, with several parts of the city receiving nearly 200 mm of rains in 12 hours, inundating low-lying areas, triggering road cave-ins, tree falls and house collapses, and disrupting road and rail traffic.

Incessant rains also disrupted normal life in neighbouring Thane, Palghar, Navi Mumbai as well as the Pune region that witnessed landslides, road closures in waterlogged areas and evacuation of people from flooded localities.

The continuous showers, coupled with the India Meteorological Department (IMD)'s extremely heavy rainfall alert, forced the civic body to declare a holiday for schools and colleges in the afternoon. Water stagnated on tracks, especially between Nalasopara and Virar stations on the Western Railway line, affecting train services. **See P4**



body to declare a holiday for schools and colleges in the afternoon. Water stagnated on tracks, especially between Nalasopara and Virar stations on the Western Railway line, affecting train services. **See P4**

FROM JULY 20 TO AUGUST 13

# Monsoon Session amid new equations

**MPOST BUREAU**

**NEW DELHI:** The Monsoon Session of Parliament will be held from July 20 to August 13 amid dramatically altered political equations after the recent Assembly elections.

The 25-day session with 19 sittings comes as cracks in the Opposition ranks seem to be widening, with beleaguered Trinamool Congress (TMC) and Shiv Sena (UBT) facing rebellion and the Congress parting ways with the DMK to join hands with the TVK to form a government in Tamil Nadu.

The BJP's recent impressive victories in West Bengal, Assam and Puducherry assembly polls have given a fresh boost to the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) after the last session ended in disappointment as a Constitutional amendment Bill to implement reservation for women in legislatures in 2029 and increase the number of seats in the Lok Sabha was defeated in the Lower House.

The government is now learnt to be redrafting the Bill to possibly increase Lok Sabha seats of all states uniformly by 50 per cent. The population-linked increase in seats has been a major concern for southern parties.

The aftermath of the rebellion in TMC and Shiv Sena (UBT) will also play out in the forthcoming session. A decision by Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on the demands of 20 TMC and six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs seeking recognition as separate groups is awaited. The NDA holds an estimated 314 seats in the 543-member Lok Sabha. While well above the simple majority mark of 272, it remains short of the 363 seats required to pass major Constitutional Amendment Bills.

In the Rajya Sabha, after newly elected and re-elected MPs took oath, the political numbers further tilted in favour of the ruling NDA. **Continued on P4**



**NDA holds 314 Lok Sabha seats, above majority but short of the 363 needed for Constitutional amendments**

17 PAKISTANIS, 6 KASHMIRIS ADDED TO UAPA LIST

# 'Zero tolerance': 23 more on terror list

**NARESH BISWANI**

**NEW DELHI:** The Union Home ministry has taken suo motu action against 23 more persons, including 17 Pakistanis and six Kashmiri Muslims, for their role in anti-India activities. Home minister Amit Shah said that the government's zero tolerance policy towards terrorism would ensure "maximum security" to the country. The recent notification under Section 35 of Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) makes the total number of accused terror suspects since 2019 as 57.

It may be recalled that the government had notified five Pakistan-based terrorists and two Kashmiri militants under the UAPA in June 2019.

The accused who were functioning out of Pakistan or Pakistan-administered Jammu and Kashmir were associated with banned organisations like Lashkar-e-Taiba, Jaish-e-Mohammed, Al-Qaeda and ISIS and involved in cross border terrorism, fundraising, arms smuggling through drones, and terrorism through cyberspace.

Some of the accused named in the notification were connected with several terror strikes in India. They include Mufti Mohammad Asghar Khan, military commander of Jaish-e-Mohammed in Pakistan-administered Kashmir (PoK) and accused in 2015 Nagrota Army camp attack, Hafiz Khalid Waleed, son-in-law of Lashkar-e-Taiba chief Hafiz Saeed and accused in 2016 Pampore attack, Abdul Rauf, top Lashkar commander designated as global terrorist by the US and Maulana

**HIGHLIGHTS**

- » The recent notification under Section 35 of Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) makes the total number of accused terror suspects since 2019 as 57
- » It may be recalled that the government had notified five Pakistan-based terrorists and two Kashmiri militants under the UAPA in June 2019



med, Al-Qaeda and ISIS and involved in cross border terrorism, fundraising, arms smuggling through drones, and terrorism through cyberspace.

Some of the accused named in the notification were connected with several terror strikes in India. They include Mufti Mohammad Asghar Khan, military commander of Jaish-e-Mohammed in Pakistan-administered Kashmir (PoK) and accused in 2015 Nagrota Army camp attack, Hafiz Khalid Waleed, son-in-law of Lashkar-e-Taiba chief Hafiz Saeed and accused in 2016 Pampore attack, Abdul Rauf, top Lashkar commander designated as global terrorist by the US and Maulana

Imdad Ullah Makki, aide to Jaish commander Masood Azhar, who facilitated 2016 Pathankot attack.

The accused who have been operating from across the border and infiltrating Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) include Firdous Ahmed Bhat, Haroon Rashid Ganai, Bilal Ahmed Mir, Abid Qayoom Lone, Nazir Ahmed Gujjar and Owais Farooq. They had left the country on valid travel documents and on reaching Pakistan, started planning and strategizing to mobilize manpower in J&K and create networks for smuggling narcotics and arms.

Mohammad Shahid Faisal has been linked to global terrorist networks **Continued on P4**

# Centre asks Telegram to curb pirated content

**NEW DELHI:** The Centre has served a notice to popular messaging app Telegram, directing it to crack down on the "widespread dissemination" of pirated films, OTT content and other audiovisual material through its platform, government officials said on Saturday.

In its notice, the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting sought an Action Taken Report from Telegram within 15 days, with officials underlining that the government's approach marks a shift from piecemeal takedowns of pirated content to "platform accountability". **See P4**



# India-Israel investment pact comes into effect

‘The pact will provide protection to two-way investments and is likely to boost cross-border investment activity’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The India-Israel Bilateral Investment Agreement (BIA), which will ensure a secure and predictable investment climate between the two countries, came into force from Saturday, the Finance Ministry said.

The pact, which will provide protection to the two-way investments, is expected to contribute to increased cross-border investment activity, it said.

The two countries inked the treaty on September 8 last year. “The BIA between the Government of the Republic of India and the Government of the State of Israel... enters into



force with effect from today, 04 July 2026,” the ministry said.

Under the pact, India has cut down the local remedies exhaustion period for Israeli investors to three years.

Local remedies exhaustion means that investors must first try to resolve their disputes using the legal system of the host country before they can take the matter to international

arbitration. Normally, India keeps a five-year period for this.

The India-Israel BIA also includes portfolio investments in a deviation from such treaties in the past. Israel is the first OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development) member with which India has inked this agreement.

The agreement is expected to pave the way for increased bilateral investments between the two countries. During April 2000 and March 2026, India received \$371.35 million foreign direct investment from Israel.

The implementation of the pact is important as both countries are also negotiating a free trade pact. The negotiations for the trade pact are going slow

due to the West Asia crisis. India is also negotiating bilateral investment treaties with other countries, including Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Oman, Switzerland, Russia, Australia and the EU.

These investment treaties help in protecting and promoting investments in each other's countries. The government has earlier announced revamping the current model of BITs to make it more investor-friendly and attract foreign players.

Commenting on the pact, think tank GTRI said the 2015 model text treaty has excluded portfolio investments, while the Israel agreement covers shares, stocks and other equity holdings, as well as qualifying bonds, loans and other corporate debt.

# DOJ seeks dismissal of charges in Adani case

NEW YORK: The US Department of Justice has forcefully defended its decision to abandon the criminal case against Indian billionaire Gautam Adani and seven others, telling a federal judge the prosecution was legally flawed, diplomatically counterproductive and inconsistent with the Trump administration's enforcement priorities.

In a sharply worded 10-page filing, the DOJ said the case “should have been dropped a year ago — or never brought in the first place,” arguing that the court had only a limited role in reviewing its decision to dismiss charges with prejudice.

The filing came after US District Judge Nicholas Garaufis asked the department to explain why it was seeking to permanently dismiss the indictment, calling its earlier motion “terse, bland, and conclusory.”

DOJ had in 2024 under the Biden administration indicted Adani and others for allegedly being involved in a scheme to bribe Indian government officials to the tune of \$250 million and to lie to investors to receive billions more in investments



from other entities — during which alleged scheme Adani Green Energy Ltd raised at least \$175 million from US investors.

The DOJ said requiring prosecutors to publicly justify decisions to drop cases would discourage future dismissals, expose privileged internal deliberations and infringe on the executive branch's constitutional authority over charging decisions. “Judicial inquisitions into the bases for dismissal will expose privileged internal debates,” Principal Associate Deputy Attorney General R Trent McCotter wrote, adding that such demand hurt defendants by potentially chilling the Department from seeking dismissal of criminal charges it determines are not in the interests of justice.

Waiving privilege only for

this case, McCotter said he decided to dismiss the charges after months of meetings with defence lawyers, reviewing hundreds of pages of submissions and conducting his own legal analysis. “The decision to seek dismissal was not a close call,” he wrote.

The department cited six overarching reasons for dropping all charges, including that the alleged conduct was overwhelmingly centred in India, Indian authorities had investigated the allegations and found no actionable misconduct, investors suffered no financial losses, key evidence and witnesses were located abroad, the defendants were unlikely to ever appear before a US court, and the prosecution faced significant evidentiary hurdles.

“This is a foreign case,” McCotter wrote. The indictment is about “several Indians allegedly trying to bridge other Indians by paying the Indian government via complex Indian rebate programs to get Indian contracts to provide Indian electricity to Indians in India.”

“The US pretending to be the world police can cause dip-

lomatic strife and also wastes resources better spent on domestic concerns. India can better manage its internal systems than can prosecutors in Brooklyn and Washington,” McCotter wrote.

The filing also argued the criminal securities fraud charges against Gautam Adani, Sagar Adani, and Cyril Cabanes lacked a sound legal basis because the alleged misconduct occurred almost entirely outside the US and the securities transactions did not satisfy US jurisdictional requirements.

The DOJ said investors had not lost money because the notes at issue had either been fully repaid or continued to be serviced. It also questioned whether statements cited in the indictment amounted to criminal fraud, describing them as largely corporate “platitudes” and “puffery” that sophisticated institutional investors were unlikely to have relied upon. “The securities charges should never have been brought,” McCotter wrote, adding that at most the allegations warranted civil, rather than criminal, resolution.

AGENCIES

# FinMin notifies rules for determination of origin of goods under India-UK FTA

NEW DELHI: The Finance Ministry has notified the rules for determination of origin of goods under the India-UK comprehensive economic and trade agreement (CETA), which will come into force from July 15, according to a notification.

A certificate of origin is a key document required for exports to avail duty benefits under India's trade agreements with partner countries.

It is essential to establish the origin of goods to ensure that products from third countries do not wrongly avail themselves of the preferential tariff benefits under trade agreements

between the two countries.

The CBIC, in a notification, said entities authorised by the two countries are permitted to issue these certificates in their respective countries.

“These rules may be called the Customs Tariff (Determination of Origin of Goods under Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement between India and the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland) Rules, 2026. They shall come into force on the 15th July, 2026,” it said.

CETA secures duty-free access for 99 per cent of India's exports to the UK.



Reinforcing its commitment to customer-centric banking and direct stakeholder engagement, Amitava Chatterjee, MD & CEO, J&K Bank on Friday chaired a Customer Meet in Leh, where a cross-section of customers from across the district participated and shared valuable feedback on the Bank's products, services, and operational requirements. The meet was attended by Zonal Head (Ladakh) Tsewang Dorjai, DGM & Board Secretary Mohammad Shafi Mir, DGM & Special Secretary to MD Tanveer Hussain, Cluster Head Tsewang Dorjai and other senior officers of the Bank.

## CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



NTPC Renewable Energy Ltd (NTPC REL), a wholly owned subsidiary of NTPC Green Energy Ltd (NGEL), has signed a Power Purchase Agreement (PPA) with PTC India Ltd for the sale of 1,200 MW of solar power under a bilateral arrangement. The PPA was exchanged in the august presence of Dr. Manoj Kumar Jhawar, MD & CEO (PTC) and Dr. J. S. Chandok, CEO (ONGPL) and other senior officials of NGEL/NTPC REL and PTC India Limited.



Power Grid Corporation of India Ltd (POWERGRID) has secured a landmark green loan of JPY 80 billion from Japan Bank for International Cooperation (JBIC), underscoring its pivotal role in India's renewable energy transformation. The pact was signed by POWERGRID and JBIC on June 17, 2026. The facility is intended to support financing of Khayda-Nagpur HVDC transmission project highlighting the strategic collaboration between POWERGRID & JBIC to develop critical infrastructure for renewable energy integration.

## Sport

# A messy affair for Argentina

Holders escape with hearts pounding after Cape Verde scare; face Egypt next

MIAMI: Lionel Messi wiped the sweat from his forehead and breathed a sigh of relief. His Argentina teammates did the same.

A thrilling, unforgettable World Cup match with underdog Cape Verde was over — and the defending champions survived after being pushed to the brink.

Cape Verde equalized in regulation and again in extra time, but the Blue Sharks could not respond to Argentina's third goal, and La Albiceleste advanced to the Round of 16 with a 3-2 victory on Friday.

Even in defeat, the performance by Cape Verde — a tiny island nation off the western coast of Africa — will stand as one of the most remarkable stories of this, or any, World Cup.

“I have to give credit to our opponents,” Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni said. “The truth is, when people say there's no such thing as an easy opponent, today (Cape Verde) proved they're a great team.”

The go-ahead score for Argentina was credited as an own-goal after Cristian Romero's header deflected off Cape Verde's Diney Borges in the 111th minute. Messi scored early in regulation, his record-extending 20th career World Cup goal. Lisandro Marti-



Lionel Messi scored his 20th World Cup goal; RIGHT: Cape Verde players look devastated after the match



AP

nez scored in the 92nd to put Argentina ahead 2-1.

Sidny Lopes Cabral and Deroy Duarte scored for Cape Verde — both equalizers that stunned the pro-Argentine crowd in South Florida. Cabral's goal — a curling, right-footed strike past goalkeeper Emiliano Martinez in the 103rd minute — made an already wild game even more incredible, tying it at 2-all and raising the possibility of Messi facing standout Cape Verde goalkeeper Vozinha in a penalty shootout.

1  
Messi became the first player in history to score seven or more goals in two editions

Argentina pushed back in front eight minutes later, held

on from there and advanced to face Egypt — who beat Australia in a shootout earlier Friday.

“As this team has demonstrated many times, and as I've said many times, it competes,” Messi said in Spanish. “And we competed to the end.”

Cape Verde's memorable World Cup debut had been a stunning run that few outside the country of 525,000 could have predicted. Behind the stellar play of the 40-year-old Vozinha, Cape Verde became the smallest country to reach the knockout round.

AGENCIES

## Colombia edge Ghana

KANSAS CITY: The plan for Colombia against Ghana on Friday night probably did not involve making a substitution just minutes into the match.

That plan also went by the wayside when Jhon Córdoba appeared to hurt his groin.

Forced into making a rare early move, Colombia coach Néstor Lorenzo sent Luis Suárez onto the field, and he promptly delivered a sharp cross that Jhon Arias flicked into the net, resulting in the only goal on a sweltering night at Arrowhead Stadium and sending Los Cafeteros into the Round of 16 at the World Cup with a 1-0 victory over the Black Stars. “I think football is a team sport,” Lorenzo said. “Ultimately you do have little groups in certain areas, but you have to have a unit — a whole — and I think our squad has been working on that from the very onset.” Colombia have won 11 consecutive World Cup matches when scoring first.

AGENCIES

# SEEK TO END JINX IN LAST-16 CLASH Old ghosts, new threat: Brazil take on Norway and Haaland

EAST RUTHERFORD: Brazil have spent decades collecting World Cup wins like precious stones but on Sunday in New Jersey they run into opponents who stubbornly refuse to join the pile - Norway.

The record five-time champions, chasing a sixth title, face Erling Haaland, Martin Odegaard and a Norwegian side who are the only team Brazil have played and never beaten.

Since their first meeting in 1988, they have met four times. Brazil have drawn twice and lost twice, including a 2-1 defeat at the 1998 World Cup when Bebeto scored for the South Americans before Tore Andre Flo and Kjetil Rekdal replied for Norway.

Brazil still topped that group, but the historical hurt remains. Norway, Hungary and Portugal are the only nations Brazil have faced at a World Cup without registering at least one victory.

Now Norway arrive brimming with hope and a talismanic centre forward in Haaland who is one of the best in the world.

Stale Solbakken's side finished runners-up in Group I after rotating almost their entire starting XI against France on matchday three, having already secured a top-two



Norway's Erling Haaland during a training session

REUTERS

## Brazil have never beaten Norway

place with back-to-back wins.

The gamble seemed to have worked, with Norway beating Ivory Coast 2-1 in the round of 32 to claim the Scandinavian nation's first World Cup knockout victory, after previous exits to Italy in 1938 and 1998.

Solbakken was a player in that squad 28 years ago and now has the chance to guide Norway to their first World Cup quarterfinal as a coach. With 17 wins and only three losses in the last two years, his team have enough good form

behind them to make Brazil wary even before Haaland starts prowling.

“Haaland is a great player and he has already shown that on several occasions, both when he was in Germany and now in England; we have a healthy relationship,” Brazil striker Matheus Cunha told a press conference. The pair have faced each other in the EPL where Haaland plays for Manchester City and Cunha is at rivals United. “But we have to focus on the whole team, as they have other dangerous players — many of whom also play in England — making Norway one of the toughest opponents,” Cunha added.

AGENCIES

# Giant-killing acts by Eala, Mertens at Wimbledon

LONDON: Iga Swiatek's Wimbledon title defence went up in smoke as the Polish third seed fell 7-6(9) 6-2 to rising Filipina Alexandra Eala in the third round after a fierce gladiatorial battle at the All England Club on Saturday.

Last year's triumph ended years of questions about Swiatek's ability to master the sport's fastest surface, yet the



25-year-old arrived at the All England Club following an

early defeat in the Bad Homburg tune-up event and still seeking consistency.

After battling past Taylor Townsend and sealing an assured win over Karolina Pliskova in her last two rounds, Swiatek came up against an inspired Eala in their Centre Court showdown and fell short under the blazing afternoon sun. “I don't know how to

describe it,” said an emotional Eala. “I mean, I'm in the second week of a Grand Slam, and it's amazing for me.”

Second seed Elena Rybakina's hopes of a second Grand Slam title this year and taking over as world No. 1 ended as she faded to a 7-6(4) 6-1 third-round defeat by inspired Belgian Elise Mertens.

AGENCIES



# As geopolitical clouds lift, Delhi calls employees back to office

Government ends austerity-era WFH, restores normal timings

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With the geopolitical situation showing signs of stabilisation, the Delhi government on Saturday withdrew its work-from-home (WFH) policy and staggered office timings for government employees, ending fuel-conservation measures that had been introduced during the recent conflict in West Asia.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta approved the rollback after officials assessed that the international situation, which had disrupted global energy markets and prompted precautionary measures, had largely normalised.

“Now that the geopolitical situation has practically normalised, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has approved withdrawal of Work from Home on Wednesdays and Saturdays,” the Chief Minister’s Office (CMO) said in a statement.

The government has also restored regular office timings. Employees will now work from 10 am to 6.30 pm, replacing the



CM Rekha Gupta at the NBT Utsav 2026 on Saturday

PTI

earlier schedule of 10.30 am to 7 pm that had been introduced as part of the temporary energy-saving initiative.

The WFH arrangement, announced in May, allowed employees to work remotely twice a week and was part of a broader package aimed at reducing fuel consumption and easing pressure on energy resources. The measures followed Prime Minister Naren-

dra Modi’s call for austerity and conservation after the Iran conflict disrupted oil supplies passing through the Strait of Hormuz, raising concerns over global fuel availability and prices.

The Delhi government’s initiative formed part of its 90-day ‘Mera Bharat, Mera Yodgan’ campaign, under which departments were asked to minimise fuel use while ensuring that

## HM Shah to inaugurate mega plantation drive on July 7: CM

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday said Union Home Minister Amit Shah will inaugurate the Delhi government’s mega drive to plant 70 lakh trees across the national capital on July 7. She encouraged residents to participate in the campaign by enrolling through the Green Drive Portal.

In a statement, Gupta said residents can use the portal to book plantation slots, collect free saplings from government nurseries, invite the ‘Vriksh Rath’ (tree chariot) that will assist them in community plantation drives and register themselves as ‘Delhi Green Warriors’. “We had promised to plant 70 lakh trees in Delhi. Now it is time to fulfil it, together. The Green Drive Portal is now live.”

AGENCIES

public services continued without disruption. Private companies, educational institutions and other organisations were also advised to adopt similar flexible working arrangements wherever feasible.

To facilitate the transition, the labour department had established a single-window help desk and a dedicated call centre to resolve operational issues faced by departments

and employees implementing the new system.

With the rollback, government offices will return to normal functioning, marking the end of the temporary conservation measures introduced during the period of geopolitical uncertainty. A formal government order detailing the revised work arrangements and implementation timeline is expected to be issued shortly.

## Delhi Police’s comic lesson on child safety

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has launched a Digital Comic Awareness Campaign as part of its ongoing ‘Child Safety Awareness Month’ initiative, using interactive comic booklets to spread awareness about child safety among schoolchildren and their parents.

A training session was organised at PHQ for school teachers, who have been designated as Master Trainers. They will play a crucial role in educating students.

MPST

## CISF strengthens Metro security with 22 women commandos

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The CISF has inducted 22 women commandos in the Quick Reaction Team (QRT) that provides security cover to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC). The personnel have been inducted to provide better response to any kind of emergency within the metro network spread across the national capital.

The newly inducted personnel have been posted at var-

## 52 finance officers shifted in govt reshuffle

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Saturday issued transfer orders of 52 finance officer, who had served at the same posting for five years or more.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the transfers and promotions have been made purely on administrative grounds to promote integrity and transparency in the system.

“The government’s objective is to establish an administrative system that meets the highest standards of transparency, accountability, efficiency and good governance. There is no place for laxity, negligence or corruption at any level,” she said.

“Twenty-three deputy controllers of accounts and 29 senior accounts officers are among those transferred. In addition, 19 senior accounts officers have been promoted as Deputy Controllers of Accounts in recognition of their performance, expanding their responsibilities in financial management across departments,” a statement said.

The chief minister said the extensive reshuffle is part of the government’s commitment

### Highlights

- Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the transfers and promotions have been made purely on administrative grounds to promote integrity and transparency in the system
- All 71 officers have been directed to assume charge at their new places of posting immediately and carry out their responsibilities accordingly

to build a more accountable, result-oriented and public-centric work culture.

“Timely decision-making, effective financial management and accountable administration will accelerate implementation of government schemes and ensure public services are delivered in a more transparent and efficient manner,” Gupta further said.

All 71 officers have been directed to assume charge at their new places of posting immediately and carry out their responsibilities accordingly.

## Gymkhana members, staff move HC over eviction

NEW DELHI: Delhi Gymkhana Club members and staff have moved the Delhi High Court against the Centre’s show-cause notice for eviction from its premises on Safdarjung Road.

The applications, which seek a stay on the operation of the show-cause notice, have been listed for hearing before Justice Avneesh Jhingon on July 6. The pleas by Vijay Khurana and Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd Staff Welfare Association form part of their pending lawsuit following the Land and Development Office’s (L&DO) May 22 order asking the colonial-era club to return its land by June 5 on grounds of “strengthening and securing defence infrastructure”.

On June 29, the L&DO under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry issued a show-cause notice to the club, asking it to explain why an eviction order should not be passed against it under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, 1971.

The notice, issued by Estate Officer Bipin Kumar Singh on June 29, has directed the club and all persons concerned occupying the premises to submit their response by July 7 and appear for a personal hearing on the same day at 2.30 pm.

The move came more than a month after the Centre told the Delhi High Court on May 26 that it would not take forcible possession of the 27.3-acre premises by June 5, which is required for “strengthening and securing defence infrastructure”. Vijay Khurana, a Gymkhana Club member, has said in his lawsuit that the “vague and generalised reasons” of defence infrastructure and security given by the Centre were just a “sham”.

The move, he claimed, was an “attempt to effect forced eviction” instead of following the due process of law.

MPST

## Mayor orders crackdown on rule-violating spas, seeks e-cart policy

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Mayor Pravech Wahi on Saturday directed officials of the MCD to intensify enforcement against spa centres and commercial establishments violating civic regulations, while also asking the civic body to formulate an e-cart policy at the earliest.

Chairing a review meeting with the MCD’s Public Health Department, Wahi instructed Deputy Health Officers across all 12 zones to



hold weekly review meetings and strengthen surveillance to prevent incidents similar to those reported in Lucknow and Delhi’s Malviya Nagar. The meeting was attended by Dep-

uty Mayor Dr. Monika Pant, Municipal Health Officers Dr. Ashok Rawat and Dr. Lallan Ram Verma, along with zonal health officials.

The Mayor directed officials to maintain strict monitoring of spa centres under the MCD’s jurisdiction, stating that violations of civic rules would not be tolerated. He also urged the Delhi Police to assist in surveillance and enforcement measures. Wahi further ordered intensified inspections of hotels and motels.

## NDMC Suvidha Camp logs 60 public grievances

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Saturday said its monthly Suvidha Camp received 60 public grievances, with complaints spanning personnel, civil engineering, horticulture, public health, enforcement, commercial, tax and estate-related issues.

Held at the NDCC Convention Centre on Jai Singh Road, the camp brought together over 100 officials from 30 NDMC departments to provide a single-window platform for grievance redressal and public assistance. According to the civic body, the complaints were taken up by the respective departments for prompt action.

Apart from grievance registration, the camp also saw residents seeking information on civic services, welfare schemes and other citizen-oriented facilities.

## DDA Advisory Council discusses housing, pollution, traffic woes

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Advisory Council of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Saturday reviewed key challenges confronting the Capital’s urban landscape and discussed a roadmap for sustainable and inclusive development at a meeting chaired by Lieutenant Governor VK Saxena.

The meeting, attended by council members, including MPs Ramvir Singh Bidhuri and Sudhanshu Trivedi, senior DDA officials and representatives of agencies such as the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), National Capital Region Transport Corporation (NCRTC), Delhi Jal Board, Power Department, Health Department of the Delhi government and the Union Ministry of Labour

and Employment, deliberated on the “Perspective for Sustainable Urban Development” in Delhi.

The Council identified several priority areas requiring planned intervention, including the shortage of affordable housing, proliferation of slums and jhuggi-jhopri clusters, their relocation and rehabilitation, regularisation and redevelopment of unauthorised colonies, development and regulation in Zone-O, urban flooding, urban heat islands, deterioration of heritage structures and water security.

Addressing the meeting, the L-G stressed that Delhi’s future growth should be “inclusive, sustainable and future-ready”, with coordinated planning among agencies to address the city’s long-term urban challenges.

## President reappoints Yogesh Singh as DU V-C

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: President Droupadi Murmu, in her capacity as the Visitor of University of Delhi, has approved the reappointment of Professor Yogesh Singh as the university’s Vice-Chancellor for a second consecutive five-year term.

With this appointment, Prof. Singh becomes the first Vice-Chancellor in the university’s history to receive two successive terms. His new tenure will commence after the completion of his current term in October 2026.

The reappointment follows changes made to the university’s statutes, which now permit an incumbent Vice-Chancellor to be considered for one additional term. Earlier regulations did not allow consecutive reappointments.

Prof. Singh assumed office as the 23rd Vice-Chancellor of the University of Delhi in October 2021.

## DDA extends Towering Heights payment deadline to July 31

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has extended the deadline for payment of Demand-cum-Allotment Letters (DALs) issued to allottees under its Towering Heights, Karkardooma Housing Scheme 2025 (e-Auction) and the Towering Heights, Karkardooma Housing Scheme 2026 (First Come First Serve).

According to an order issued with the approval of the DDA Vice Chairman, allottees whose 60-day interest-free payment period has already expired will now be allowed to make payments without any interest up to July 31, 2026.

The authority said the extension was granted in view of the time likely to be required for obtaining statutory approvals, the prevailing geopolitical situation

and representations received from allottees seeking additional time to complete payments.

The DDA has also provided a further 30-day grace period up to August 30, 2026, during which payments can still be made. However, interest at the rate of 10 per cent per annum will be levied for payments made during this period, in accordance with the scheme provisions.

### RAIN, GUSTS TO PREVAIL OVER NEXT FEW DAYS

## Light showers cool parts of city; more rain likely

NEW DELHI: The capital recorded a slight dip in maximum temperature on Saturday as light to moderate rainfall was witnessed in parts of the city, with the weather office forecasting that similar conditions will prevail over the next few days.

Safdarjung, the city’s base weather station, recorded a maximum of 35.4 degrees Celsius, two degrees below normal, and 0.4 degrees lower than Friday.

### The maximum temperature is likely to dip further to around 32-34°C on Sunday

The minimum temperature settled at 29 degrees Celsius, 1.1 degree below normal, but 0.9 degrees higher than the day before.

Safdarjung received no rain till 5.30 pm Saturday, according to India Meteorological department (IMD) data.

However, the Pusa weather station recorded 23.5 mm rainfall between 11.30 am and 2.30 pm, Janakpuri saw 9.5 mm rainfall during the same period; while Pitampura recorded 0.5 mm rain between 2.30 pm and 5.30 pm.

Other weather stations also

marked a decrease in maximum temperatures on Saturday.

Palam recorded a maximum of 35.1 degrees Celsius, a one-degree dip from a day before; Lodhi Road recorded a maximum of 35.2 degrees Celsius, 0.6 degrees less than Friday’s maximum; Ridge and Ayanagar recorded maximums at 36.4 degrees and 34.6 degrees Celsius respectively, 0.5 and 0.7 degrees lower than Friday’s.

AGENCIES



**DELHI STATE LEGAL SERVICES AUTHORITY**  
IN COORDINATION WITH  
**DELHI TRAFFIC POLICE**  
*is Organising*  
**SPECIAL LOK ADALAT**  
**AT SEVEN COURT COMPLEXES**  
**ON 12<sup>th</sup> JULY, 2026**



**COURT COMPLEXES**

**PATIALA HOUSE**

**KARKARDOOMA**

**TIS HAZARI**

**SAKET**

**ROHINI**

**DWARKA**

**ROUSE AVENUE**

1. Only compoundable Traffic challans/notices pending on **Delhi Traffic Police portal** and forwarded to **Virtual Court** till **31.03.2026** will be taken up in **this Lok Adalat**.

2. All the **Notices/Challans** are to be downloaded from Delhi Traffic Police website i e **https://traffic.delhipolice.gov.in/lokadalat** Or by **scanning the QR Code**.

3. **It is mandatory to carry a print out of the Notices/Challans**, as no printing facility will be available at the court complexes.

**Scan QR Code 1  
Steps for  
booking online  
appointment**

**Scan QR Code 2:  
Downloading  
Notices/  
Challans**

**This link will be activated on **06.07.2026 at 10:00 am**, Maximum of **50,000 Challans/Notices** may be downloaded per day subject to an overall limit of **2,00,000 Challans/Notices**.**

**FOR MORE DETAILS**

Follow us on :- WhatsApp: 8750871493 @dtptraffic @dtptraffic @dtptraffic

**24 HOURS TRAFFIC HELPLINE**  
**011-25844444/1095**

**DELHI STATE LEGAL SERVICES AUTHORITY**  
Rouse Avenue District Court, 3<sup>rd</sup> Floor,  
Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyay Marg, New Delhi-110002  
**HELPLINE: 1516**

**BE A TRAFFIC PRAHARI**  
**Download App from**  


**Website: [www.traffic.delhipolice.gov.in](http://www.traffic.delhipolice.gov.in) | E-mail: [info.traffic@delhipolice.gov.in](mailto:info.traffic@delhipolice.gov.in)**

DP/9894/2026



CHAMPAT RAI AND ANIL MISHRA ARE NOT OUTSIDERS BUT PART AND PARCEL OF RSS'S ORGANISATIONAL MILIEU

# From Triumph to Turmoil: A crisis of credibility for Sangh Parivar

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The consecration of the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya was meant to symbolise the culmination of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's (RSS) century-long ideological journey and reinforce the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) political dominance.

But as the Sangh Parivar celebrates this historic milestone, a donation embezzlement case and political achievement.

More than a financial scandal, the episode threatens to dent the RSS's moral authority, strain ties within the Sangh ecosystem, and potentially influence the political narrative ahead of crucial Assembly elections.

The real question is why this particular controversy has put the Sangh Parivar on the back foot, making the top brass issue an unequivocal condemnation of the entire matter. The reasons for this



can be understood from the RSS's basic ideology, in which strict adherence to ideology, personal conduct, and financial prudence have always been considered the building blocks of character.

The reason why this particular controversy is harmful for the organisation is that the people accused of this matter, Champat Rai and Anil Mishra, are not outsiders but part and parcel of RSS's organisational milieu.

The general secretary of

RSS, Dattatreya Hosabale, on Friday, had to issue a visual statement, where he condemned and said, "...The unfortunate incident of theft in the donation boxes kept at the Shri Ram Lalla temple in Ayodhya has deeply hurt the sentiments and faith of the entire society and Ram devotees; we are all extremely pained and angered by this event."

Adding, "At the earnest request of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, the Uttar Pradesh gov-

## Highlights

» More than a financial scandal, the episode threatens to dent the RSS's moral authority, strain ties within the Sangh ecosystem

» The real question is why this particular controversy has put the Sangh Parivar on the back foot, making the top brass issue an unequivocal condemnation of the entire matter

ernment constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT) and initiated legal proceedings based on its recommendations. It is essential to ensure that anyone found guilty after the investigation faces severe punishment."

The senior functionary of Sangh Parivar also said that the temple has become a centre

of reverence, faith, and devotion for the entire Hindu society, owing to the struggles of generations and the dedication, sacrifice, and martyrdom of crores of Rambhaktas. (Devotees.)

Hosabale further underlined, "The unfortunate incident of theft in the donation boxes kept at the Shri Ram Lalla temple in Ayodhya has deeply hurt the sentiments and faith of the entire society and Ram devotees; we are all extremely pained and angered by this event."

Terming it "highly condemnable," the RSS stated that it was incumbent upon the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust to regard it as an "extraordinary case" and initiate corrective action to rectify the defects and weaknesses in the management and functioning of the temple.

According to Hosabale, the "faith of crores of Ram bhaktas needed to remain unbroken and firm," and he appealed to

both the Trust and the Special Investigation Team constituted by the government to ensure an investigation that is transparent.

RSS chief, Mohan Bhagwat, on the other hand, in Nagpur refused to comment while being questioned regarding the donation embezzlement issue. While the media tried to seek a comment from him, all that Bhagwat did was raise his hand acknowledging the question and saying "Ram-Ram", before leaving without making any remarks.

He asserted that "anti-Hindu and anti-national forces" were trying to besmirch the "Hindu dharma through this unfortunate incident," and appealed to people not to be misled.

Taking the matter forward, BJP leader and Bajrang Dal chief Vinay Katiyar maintained that he informed PM Narendra Modi that Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust General Secretary Cham-

pat Rai and other trust officials could be behind bars in connection with the Ram Temple donation embezzlement scandal.

Adding that PM Modi "expressed concern" over the issue and sought his assessment of the situation. Katiyar said he assured Modi that "everything would be fine."

After the judgment from the Supreme Court, Champat Rai was appointed as the General Secretary of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust in 2020 and became the main administrator of Ram Mandir construction.

The bhoomi puja and pran pratishtha ceremony were carried out by the Prime Minister Modi in August 2020 and January 2024, respectively. Also, Rai, on many occasions, praised the leadership of PM Modi. Especially, prior to the temple's inauguration in 2024, Rai caused quite a stir in the press by lavishing praise on

Modi to such an extent that "the king is an incarnation of Vishnu," when speaking about the Prime Minister's part in the ceremony.

Meanwhile, a critical meeting will be held on Monday by the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust to discuss important matters of administration and finances, and the findings of the Special Investigation Team (SIT) investigating the supposed irregularities regarding the calculation of temple offerings are expected to top the discussion.

This meeting, arranged after obtaining permission from the Trust Chairman, was convened by the Treasurer Swami Govind Dev Giri via a notification dated June 28.

Some of the critical points that are likely to be discussed include the resignation letters of the General Secretary Champat Rai and Trustee Anil Mishra, whose positions are under question owing to the ongoing controversy.

## Modi greets Trump, people of US on 250th anniversary of independence

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday greeted President Donald Trump and the people of the United States on the 250th anniversary of America's independence and said the two countries' shared belief in democracy and the rule of law, and the limitless potential of their people make the friendship a force for global good.

Modi asserted that India and the United States share more than a strategic partnership.

"On behalf of 1.4 billion Indians, I extend my warmest congratulations to President Trump and the people of the United States on the historic 250th anniversary of your Independence," the prime minister said in a post on X.

He said the shared belief of India and the US in democracy and the rule of law, and the limitless potential of "our people make our friendship a force for global good".



"May the next 250 years bring even greater prosperity, peace and progress for America and take the India-US partnership to new heights," he said.

Trump ushered in the 250th anniversary of American independence on Friday.

The signing of the Declaration of Independence, one of history's most-celebrated articulations of democratic ambitions, is being marked in myriad ways.

Set to take a central role in the festivities, Trump plans to speak at the National Mall in Washington ahead of what is being billed as a historically-enormous fireworks show that will rain down over the US capital.

## Heavy rains disrupt normal life in Maha, Kerala; IMD says monsoon to advance further north

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Heavy rains threw life out of gear in several states on Saturday, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issuing red alerts in Maharashtra, West Bengal, Odisha and Kerala, and stating that conditions were favourable for the advance of southwest monsoon into the remaining parts of Haryana and Punjab and Rajasthan in the next four days.

Two days after monsoon arrived in national capital Delhi, parts of the city witnessed light to moderate rainfall. The weather office has forecast that light rain and gusts would prevail at least till Friday.

After the late arrival of monsoon in Maharashtra, incessant heavy rains lashed Mumbai and its metropolitan region, triggering incidents of road cave-in, tree fall and house collapse, and disrupting road and rail traffic.

Continuous downpour forced the Brihanmumbai



Commuters make their way through a waterlogged road amid heavy rainfall, in Mumbai, Maharashtra, Saturday

PTI

Municipal Corporation (BMC) to declare a holiday for schools and colleges in the afternoon.

The showers led to waterlogging in several low-lying areas of the metropolis, crippling public transport services and posing difficulties for private vehicle users.

Water stagnated on tracks on the Western Railway line, affecting train services.

The BMC reported 64 incidents of tree falls, eight house or wall collapses. In one incident, a two-storey structure

collapsed at Banewadi in Byculla, injuring two men and one woman.

In neighbouring Palghar, a six-year-old child died after being washed away in floodwaters, while authorities rescued more than 180 people stranded in waterlogged localities.

Heavy rains accompanied by gusty winds lashed several parts of Kerala, leading to a rise in water levels in rivers and dams, inundation in low-lying areas and damage to property.

In Idukki district, author-

ities opened shutters of the Pambala dam as a precaution after heavy rainfall in the catchment areas led to a rise in the reservoir's water level.

The Indian National Centre for Ocean Information Services issued a high wave and sea erosion warning for coastal stretches in Kozhikode, Kannur and Kasaragod districts till 11.30 pm on Sunday.

Authorities asked people to move away from vulnerable coastal areas if instructed, avoid launching small boats into the sea, refrain from beach visits and sea-based recreational activities, and ensure fishing vessels are securely moored in harbours until the warning is withdrawn.

The Kerala State Disaster Management Authority urged people living in landslide, landslip and flash flood-prone areas to shift to safer places as directed by local authorities.

In Gujarat, the monsoon was active with "exceptional heavy rainfall" in Junagadh, where a few areas witnessed severe waterlogging.

## Govt asks Telegram to curb pirated content

### Warns of legal action for non-compliance

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre has served a notice to popular messaging app Telegram, directing it to crack down on the "widespread dissemination" of pirated films, OTT content and other audio-visual material through its platform, government officials said on Saturday.

In its notice, the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting sought an Action Taken Report from Telegram within 15 days, with officials underlining that the government's approach marks a shift from piecemeal takedowns of pirated content to "platform accountability".

The ministry is learnt to have told Telegram, which was temporarily blocked in India in June as a precautionary measure to prevent any paper leak during the NEET re-examination, that copyright infringement is not merely a civil violation, but also a criminal offence under the Copyright

Act, 1957, and the Cinematograph Act, 1952.

"The Ministry has made it clear that Telegram cannot merely wait for the government to identify each piracy channel one by one. A purely reactive, channel-by-channel takedown approach may not be enough to demonstrate due diligence by the platform, as required under the IT Act, 2000, and the IT Rules, 2021," officials said.

The notice to Telegram follows the Centre's recent regulatory action against Meta. On Wednesday, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) issued a notice to Meta questioning the planned username feature on WhatsApp and, later in the week, decided to summon the company over Instagram ads allegedly promoting child sexual abuse material.

Telegram and another messaging app Signal have also been served notices by MeitY on their existing username feature.

## From Page 1

## Ram Temple

trust president. Earlier, communications regarding the resignations of Rai and Mishra had also been issued without signatures.

Meanwhile, a public interest litigation seeking a Central Bureau of Investigation probe into the alleged donation theft and a Comptroller and Auditor General audit of temple offerings is likely to come up for hearing before the Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court on July 6.

The petition, filed by Ayodhya-based advocate Mohit Ashok, seeks a CBI investigation into the alleged embezzlement of cash donations, gold and silver ornaments and other valuables offered at the temple. It also seeks a CAG audit of the offerings, arguing that the allegations concern the assets of a temple that symbolises the faith of millions of Hindus.

With both the trust meeting and the court hearing scheduled for the same day, all eyes are on Ayodhya as decisions taken in the coming days could shape the future leadership and accountability mechanisms of the Ram Temple trust.

Meanwhile, the daily collection of donations at the Ram Janmabhoomi Temple in Ayodhya has witnessed a sharp increase since the investigation into the alleged theft of temple offerings began, prompting investigators to examine whether there were irregularities in the handling of donations before the case came to light.

According to sources, the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust's bank accounts were receiving an average of Rs 16 lakh to Rs 18 lakh in donations every day before the alleged theft surfaced. Since the Special Investigation Team (SIT) launched

its probe, the daily deposits have reportedly increased to between Rs 24 lakh and Rs 26 lakh.

The jump of nearly Rs 6 lakh to Rs 8 lakh a day has become a key focus of the investigation. Officials are trying to ascertain whether the difference points to possible embezzlement or diversion of donations before the case was exposed.

Despite the controversy, devotees continue to donate in large numbers through both cash and digital modes at the donation counters located at the Yatri Sahayata Kendra near the temple's Singh Dwar.

Sources associated with the trust said a single donation counter receives between Rs 60,000 and Rs 1 lakh every day. On holidays and special occasions, the amount can rise to nearly Rs 2 lakh. The temple complex has around 10 donation counters that remain open from 7 am to 9 pm.

The donations received at the temple are deposited in accounts maintained with the State Bank of India and Punjab National Bank. The SIT is scrutinising bank transactions, donation records and the role of employees handling the offerings as it seeks to determine whether the sharp rise in collections after the probe began has any connection with the alleged theft of temple donations.

"This itself shows how much money may have been embezzled earlier. If the collections can suddenly go up by Rs 6 lakh to Rs 8 lakh a day after the investigation started, then serious questions arise about where that money was going before," said Manish Sharma, a resident of Ayodhya.

## PM

world's fourth-largest country in refining capacity and this capacity will continue to grow," he said.

The prime minister spoke about how LPG production was

maximised, PNG connections increased and energy imports were sourced from more than 40 countries to overcome the crisis and shield citizens in India from the worst impact of the crisis.

He said oil companies incurred losses of over Rs 75,000 crore between April and June due to rising global prices, but the government absorbed the burden.

"In several countries, diesel and petrol prices rose by 40 to 50 per cent and fuel was distributed through quotas. India did not witness such a situation even for a single day.

"Rumours were spread, people were frightened and political games were played, but those with wrong intentions did not succeed," he said, apparently attacking the Congress and other opposition parties.

He noted the government was working round the clock at the policy and diplomatic levels to tackle the crisis. Every sensitive decision taken during that period will one day become part of history. What India achieved during this crisis is unprecedented, he said.

"Those who wished to see India fail had even begun making predictions... their malicious intentions did not succeed," he said.

Modi said nearly 70 per cent of India's LPG requirement was met through imports and about 90 per cent of those supplies came from Gulf countries through the Strait of Hormuz. The conflict had nearly halted those supplies.

He said the government immediately decided to maximise domestic refining capacity for LPG production.

"Industrial gas production was shifted in favour of LPG production. Within seven days, refinery output of LPG increased significantly. During the crisis, LPG production went up by 54,000 metric tonnes. Refineries that had never produced LPG earlier were also reconfigured," he said.

The government simultaneously ensured that PNG connections expanded rapidly so

that domestic demand for LPG remained under control, Modi said.

"More than 11 lakh households were connected with PNG in a very short period. Domestic consumers were also protected from the burden of rising prices. Experts believed a domestic LPG cylinder could cost Rs 2,000. Today it is available at around Rs 950," he said.

He said commercial LPG prices were also reduced substantially. Referring to petroleum products, Modi said crude oil prices had surged from about USD 70 per barrel to USD 120 per barrel after the conflict escalated and supply routes were disrupted.

He said India expanded energy imports significantly during the West Asia crisis.

"When the crisis began, India was importing energy from about 25-26 countries. During the crisis, we increased this to more than 40 countries," he said, attributing the turnaround to India's diplomacy.

On oil companies incurring losses, he said, "We reduced excise duty by Rs 10 per litre and ensured that the burden on citizens did not increase significantly."

The prime minister said the country has become the world's fourth-largest in refining capacity and continues to expand. He also credited his government's long-term policies with overcoming global disruptions in fuel and fertiliser supply caused by the war between Iran and the US-Israel combine.

Talking about the refinery project, he said an agreement for the Pachpadra refinery project had been signed in 2017, but work slowed considerably during the previous Congress government in Rajasthan between 2018 and 2023.

"Because of the Congress government's lack of cooperation, work on the project almost came to a standstill. After the double-engine government came to power, work gathered pace. Today we are dedicating the project to the nation. We not only lay founda-

tion stones but also complete and inaugurate projects," he said.

The prime minister was speaking after dedicating and launching development projects worth around Rs 1.06 lakh crore. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

## Khalid, Imam

whether there is any change in circumstances, as it is bound by the Supreme Court's January 5 order dismissing the bail pleas of both applicants.

"Since then, there are no substantial change of circumstances as pleaded by the applicants and there arises no question to reconsider the bail of the applicants," it said.

The court, however, clarified that nothing stated in the order should be construed as an expression of opinion on the merits of the case.

Khalid's lawyer, Trideep Pias, told the court that there was a change in circumstances after the Supreme Court's January 5 judgment. He also relied on the subsequent Syed Iftikhar Andrabi ruling, which reaffirmed the principles in the K A Najeeb case on prolonged incarceration, and questioned the reasoning adopted in the case of Gulfisha Fatima.

"The Supreme Court has expressed serious reservations on the manner in which K A Najeeb was applied in the case of Gulfisha Fatima and expressed to the extent that the reasoning given in Gulfisha Fatima amounts to a hollowing out of the three-judge bench decision in K A Najeeb," he said.

Imam's lawyer, Talib Mustafa, pointed to the apex court's interim bail orders for co-accused Tasleem and Khalid Saifi, as well as the Delhi High Court's bail order in Khuram Parvez's case.

He argued that since both applicants had spent more than six years in custody and the protected witnesses are unlikely to be examined soon, they should be granted regular bail or, alterna-

tively, six months' interim bail.

Special public prosecutors Madhukar Pandey and Anirudha Mishra opposed the applications, arguing that the Supreme Court had already rejected the bail pleas of both Khalid and Imam, while the former's review petition was also dismissed. They submitted that the trial court was bound by those orders and could not grant them bail.

It was further argued that there was no substantial change in circumstances since the apex court's decision. Therefore, the fresh bail pleas were not maintainable as the conditions laid down by the top court for renewing the bail plea are yet to be met.

On January 5, the Supreme Court refused bail to Khalid and Imam in the larger-conspiracy case, while granting the relief to co-accused Gulfisha Fatima, Meeran Haider, Shifa Ur Rehman, Mohammad Saleem Khan and Shadab Ahmad.

A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and N V Anjaria had then observed that there was a prima-facie case against Khalid and Imam under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), and held that all accused could not be treated equally in view of the "hierarchy of participation".

Khalid, Imam and several others were booked under the anti-terrorism UAPA and provisions of the Indian Penal Code (IPC) for allegedly being part of a larger conspiracy behind the February 2020 riots in northeast Delhi.

The violence had erupted during protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA) and the proposed National Register of Citizens (NRC), leaving 53 people dead and more than 700 injured.

## Monsoon Session

Three rebel TMC MPs from the Upper House have quit and bypolls will help the BJP gather

more strength in the Rajya Sabha.

In a post on X, Rijji said that, on the recommendation of the government, President Draupadi Murmu has summoned both the Houses of Parliament for the Monsoon Session 2026.

"The Session will commence on 20 July, 2026 and continue till 13 August, 2026 for meaningful debate, discussion and decisions on issues of national importance," he said.

A Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining the controversial 130th Constitution Amendment Bill is likely to adopt its report on July 17. There are indications that it will retain the Bill's most debated provision mandating the automatic removal of the Prime Minister, Chief Ministers and Union or State ministers from office if they are jailed for 30 consecutive days in cases involving serious offences.

The JPC is expected to finalise and adopt its report at its meeting on July 17 before submitting it to Parliament for further consideration. The Opposition is also expected to bring up the issue of privilege proceedings against Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, after the Congress alleged that he spoke a "straightforward, clear-cut lie" to mislead the House over casualties of Indian soldiers during Operation Sindoor. WITH INPUTS FROM AGENCIES

## 'Zero tolerance'

and named as handler for cyber terror attacks, including 2012 Bengaluru conspiracy and recent 2024 Rameshwaram café attack.

"By notifying suspected terrorists under the UAPA, necessary steps could be taken to take strict action against them under the law, including freezing of their assets, blocking of transactions and movement of suspected terrorists and to take all measures to secure India's security mechanism," said officials.



LAUNCHES MODIFIED UDAN SCHEME

# Modi inaugurates new Jodhpur airport terminal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**JODHPUR:** Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday inaugurated the new terminal building at Jodhpur airport and launched the modified UDAN Scheme.

Modi arrived in Jodhpur and was received at the airport by Governor Haribhau Bagade, Union Minister and Jodhpur MP Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, and Chief Minister Bhanjalal Sharma.

The Prime Minister unveiled the inauguration plaque by pressing a remote button and toured the new terminal building.

He also launched the Modified UDAN Scheme. With an allocation of Rs 28,840 crore over the next 10 years, the scheme aims to accelerate the next phase of aviation-led development.

The revamped scheme focuses on multiple strategic components to ensure comprehensive and sustainable air connectivity.

The new terminal building at Jodhpur airport has been developed at a total cost of Rs 480 crore. Spread over more than 23,000 square metres, it is designed to handle up to 20 lakh passengers annually.

The terminal is equipped with modern passenger amenities to provide a seamless and comfortable travel experience.

Architecturally inspired by Rajasthan's royal heritage, the terminal blends traditional elements such as arches and jharokhas with contemporary design.

Folk artistes presented cul-



A view of the newly inaugurated terminal building at Jodhpur Airport, in Jodhpur, Rajasthan, Saturday

Highlights

- » The PM unveiled the inauguration plaque by pressing a remote button and toured the new terminal building
- » The new terminal building at Jodhpur airport has been developed at a total cost of Rs 480 crore
- » Spread over more than 23,000 square metres, it is designed to handle up to 20 lakh passengers annually

tural performances during the prime minister's visit to the new terminal.

Officials said the terminal would strengthen the state's aviation infrastructure, improve air connectivity, boost tourism, expand business activities and create new employ-

ment opportunities.

The event also highlighted the achievements and progress of the UDAN scheme.

"The launch of this modern terminal will ensure better services for passengers and significantly bolster air connectivity for Jodhpur. This project will play a pivotal role in the state's economic and social development," according to an official.

Located on the city's outskirts, the terminal strengthens Jodhpur's position within Rajasthan's heritage triad of Jaipur, Udaipur, and Jodhpur, one of India's most-visited cultural corridors.

Jodhpur continues to attract global travellers for its indigo-hued old town, the iconic Mehrangarh Fort and luxury wedding destinations.

The new infrastructure addresses rising passenger demand, enabling ease of domestic connectivity while positioning Jodhpur to emerge as an international destination of choice in the coming years.

## After Op Sindoor, trust in 'made-in-India' defence platforms got enhanced: Rajnath

Singh also spoke of India's journey in various sectors in the last 12 years

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Defence minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday said that after Operation Sindoor, the trust in "made-in-India" defence platforms has received a boost.

In his address at an event here, he also reiterated that "today, our defence production has reached over Rs 1.78 lakh crore, and about 8-9 years ago, it stood at approximately Rs 46,000 crore".

The Union minister asserted that after Operation Sindoor, "trust in made-in-India defence platforms has got enhanced".

Operation Sindoor was India's decisive military action conducted in May 2025 in response to the Pahalgam ter-



Defense minister Rajnath Singh speaks during Navbharat Times (NBT) Utsav, in New Delhi, Saturday

ror attack.

Several defence platforms built in India had played a key role in it.

Singh said, "Defence exports too have reached a record over Rs 38,000 crore, and in 2013-14, it stood at just

Rs 686 crore, and it has grown today 57 times. And, I have not sought the full report, but, currently it should be hovering around Rs 40,000 crore, is my estimate."

In his address, he also spoke of India's journey in various sectors in the last 12 years, the advancement of artificial intelligence (AI) and the importance of human sensitivity in the age of AI, including in the field of journalism.

The event was hosted in Delhi to mark 80 years of the national Hindi daily Navbharat Times.

"India's journey over the last 12 years has been a progression from shortages to self-reliance, from self-reliance to self-confidence, and from self-confi-

dence towards building a Viksit Bharat," Singh said.

He said India lays emphasis on both technological development and celebrating its traditions, and this confluence of "tradition and technology" is the "biggest strength of the country in the 21st century".

Underlining that AI has touched nearly all aspects of human existence today, he cautioned that while AI can read and analyse data, it "cannot feel the pulse" of the people, which is where the human sensitivity comes into picture.

Singh pointed out that journalism too has been impacted by technological advancements such as AI, but they won't be able to surpass human creativity and intellect.

## Contribution of CAs vital to realising vision of a Viksit Bharat: CM Saini

MPOST BUREAU

**CHANDIGARH:** Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India is on the path to becoming the world's fourth-largest economy.

Today, the country is witnessing record GST collections every month, symbolising its growing economic strength. Chartered Accountants (CAs) have made a significant contribution to strengthening this tax system.

The Chief Minister assured all possible government assistance regarding the request for five acres of land to establish a 'Centre of Excellence' for the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) in Panchkula.

Chief Minister Saini was addressing the national con-

ference for CA students, 'Pragyaan 2026', as the chief guest at the Indradhanush Auditorium today. Earlier, the Chief Minister inaugurated the conference by lighting the traditional lamp.

Addressing the CA students, the Chief Minister said that their contribution is vital to realising PM Modi's vision of a Viksit Bharat.

He emphasised that the blueprint and foundation of a developed India's economic structure will be shaped by young professionals like them.

Referring to an inspiring statement made by the Prime Minister at an ICAI programme, CM Saini said that Narendra Modi had once remarked that a Chartered Accountant's signature is even more powerful than that of the Prime Minister.

The Chief Minister said that while governments for-

mulate policies, schemes, and programmes, it is the signature of a Chartered Accountant that often influences the direction and health of the economy.

He said that the theme of the conference, 'Pragyaan Yash Ka Path' conveys the message that success is not attained through talent alone but through hard work, integrity, discipline, and a commitment to lifelong learning.

Meanwhile, CM Saini has directed the Tourism Department to redevelop the historic Yadavindra Garden in Pinjore and the picturesque Tikkar Taal in Morni Hills in accordance with modern and international standards.

The directions were issued during a high-level review meeting held with senior officers of the Tourism Department on late Friday evening.

## Cong condemns RSS gen secy's remarks on Ram Mandir donation theft

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The Congress on Saturday termed RSS General Secretary Dattatreya Hosabale's statement on the theft of offerings at the Ram Mandir as "crocodile tears", asserting that the organisation could not absolve itself of responsibility merely by issuing a public statement.

Uttar Pradesh Congress Legislature Party leader Aradhana Misra said the BJP and the RSS were seeking to distance themselves from the controversy through a scripted statement, and questioned Prime Minister Narendra Modi's silence on the issue.

Misra said senior office-bearers of the shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust were associated with the RSS and that the theft had taken place under their supervision. Naming Champat Rai Bansal, Anil Mishra and Gopal Rao, she asked whether they were linked to the organisation, and if the RSS was genuinely distressed by the incident, why no action had been taken against them.

She questioned why no FIR had been registered against senior Trust officials, alleging that lower-level employees had been arrested while senior functionaries were shielded.

The Trust, she added, had recruited personnel through the State Bank of India and an agency without conducting adequate background verification.

Targeting the BJP government, Misra also questioned the inaction of the Enforcement Directorate, the Central Bureau of Investigation and the Income Tax Department over the financial irregularities linked to the temple.

She said there was no proper accounting of offerings received from devotees, including around 1,250 'Ram Shilas' and jewellery worth crores of rupees, and that the Trust had been kept outside the purview of the RTI Act.

## CJP urges PM Modi to break 'resounding silence' over its protest

**NEW DELHI:** The Cockroach Janta Party on Saturday released an open letter addressed to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, urging him to break his "resounding silence" over its protest at the Jantar Mantar and hold Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan accountable for alleged exam paper leaks and student suicides.

In the two-page letter titled "A Question of Humanity: How Long Will You Ignore Jantar Mantar?", the CJP said its protest had entered its 15th day while activist Sonam Wangchuk was on the seventh day of his indefinite fast.

The letter, signed by Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke and spokespersons Saurav Das, Ashutosh Ranka, Vaishnavi Gaur, Aafreen Nawaz, Deepak Baliana, Ratna Singh and Vijeta Dahiya,



A poster installed during the seventh day of a hunger strike by Cockroach Janata Party (CJP), at Jantar Mantar, in New Delhi, Saturday

also questioned why the prime-minister had not responded despite their prolonged agitation, which began at the Jantar Mantar on June 20.

"We have been sitting in protest at the Jantar Mantar for the past 15 days, and today marks the seventh day of educationist Sonam Wangchuk's indefinite hunger strike. How long will your government choose to ignore our voices,

sir?" the CJP said in the letter.

"A hunger strike in a civil society is meant to bring moral pressure upon the powers that be. The underlying principle is simple: when someone like Sonam Wangchuk, a man who has dedicated his entire life, mind and soul to this country and to the cause of education, refuses to consume food, it is supposed to elicit a conscious response, whether moral or political, from the govt of the day.

Meanwhile, the Samyukta Kisan Morcha (SKM), which had led the 2020-21 protest against the now-scrapped central farm laws, has extended support to the ongoing CJP-led sit-in against alleged exam irregularities and announced that its delegation will join the agitation at Jantar Mantar here on Sunday.

## Confident of BJP win in UP Assembly polls, says Nabin in Lucknow

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**LUCKNOW:** BJP chief Nitin Nabin on Saturday lauded Uttar Pradesh's transformation under the party's "double engine" government and said the BJP would win the Assembly polls next year.

Nabin arrived in Lucknow on a two-day visit, during which he is expected to hold a series of meetings with senior leaders to streamline the party's strategy for the 2027 Assembly polls and "guide the newly formed team of the state BJP".

His visit also comes amid a controversy over the alleged embezzlement of Ram temple's donations, an issue around which the Opposition, particularly the Samajwadi Party, has tried to corner the BJP.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath and top leaders of the party received Nabin, the youngest national BJP chief ever, at the Lucknow airport.

"The way the double-engine government Modi-Yogi duo has transformed Uttar Pradesh into Uttam Pradesh, Lotus will



BJP president Nitin Nabin greets the gathering during a party roadshow as he visits Lucknow for two days, on Saturday

bloom in Uttar Pradesh, which is home to cities of Kashi Vishwanath, Ayodhya and Mathura," Nabin told news agency.

"Based on the enthusiasm we saw today among the party workers across Lucknow and the entire state, we can say with certainty that the BJP workers are fully prepared for 2027," Nabin said, responding to his party's prospects in the 2027 Assembly polls.

UP BJP chief Pankaj Chaudhary, both Deputy Chief Ministers Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak, and other UP ministers were also present at the airport.

## Scientists recreate key functions of human Placenta on chip

Acting as the baby's first life-support system, the placenta delivers oxygen and nutrients

MPOST BUREAU

**NEW DELHI:** Before a baby's first breath, life depends on an extraordinary organ that most people rarely think about — the placenta.

Acting as the baby's first life-support system, the placenta delivers oxygen and nutrients, removes waste products, protects the developing fetus and produces hormones essential for sustaining pregnancy.

Yet, despite its critical role in human development, it remains one of the least understood human organs because it is difficult to study directly during pregnancy. But that mystery may somewhat be unravelled now.

Researchers from the ICMR-National Institute for Research on Women's Health (formerly ICMR-NIRRH), Mumbai, in collaboration with IIT Bombay, have developed an indigenous lab-grown "placenta-on-chip" platform that recreates key functions of the human placental barrier.

Key Points

- » Published in the journal Biofabrication, the study describes a microphysiological system that mimics the interface between the mother and fetus
- » The researchers said that the platform produces pregnancy hormones, transports glucose from the maternal to fetal side

Published in the journal Biofabrication, the study describes a microphysiological system that mimics the interface between the mother and fetus.

The device reproduces several essential functions of the human placenta, including hormone production, nutrient transfer, waste exchange and selective barrier function -- some of the most important biological processes that sus-

tain pregnancy.

The researchers said that the platform produces pregnancy hormones, transports glucose from the maternal to fetal side, removes waste products such as urea and responds to hyperglycaemic conditions resembling gestational diabetes.

These capabilities make it a promising platform for studying placental biology, understanding pregnancy complications, evaluating how medicines cross the placental barrier and supporting the development of more predictive human-relevant research models.

Unlike many existing placenta-on-chip systems that require sophisticated microfluidic equipment and continuous perfusion systems, the Indian platform has been designed to be simple, scalable and compatible with conventional laboratory workflows, potentially enabling wider adoption by research laboratories, authors claimed.

## 'Liver epidemic & sharp rise in Type-2 diabetes part of larger metabolic nexus'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** India's liver epidemic and the sharp rise in Type-2 diabetes are part of a larger metabolic nexus, Union Minister of State for Science & Technology Jitendra Singh said on Saturday, with fatty liver, hypertension, dyslipidaemia and insulin resistance closely interconnected and predisposing one another.

Speaking at the third anniversary of the Liver & Metabolic Disease Network (InFLiMeN) at the Institute of Liver & Biliary Sciences (ILBS), the minister said these diseases were now appearing at much younger ages than before, making the challenge far more than a medical issue and calling for a mission-mode national response driven by preven-

Conditions once associated with middle-aged and elderly populations were increasingly being diagnosed among younger adults and even adolescents, Jitendra Singh said

tive healthcare and mass public awareness.

Conditions once associated with middle-aged and elderly populations were increasingly being diagnosed among younger adults and even adolescents, he said, a shift that demanded a move from curative healthcare towards pre-

vention, early detection and lifestyle modification.

India's genetic predisposition, higher prevalence of central obesity and distinct phenotype made its population particularly vulnerable to diabetes, fatty liver and cardiovascular disease, often even at a lower Body Mass Index.

The liver, despite being the body's most resilient and regenerative organ, was coming under stress from unhealthy dietary habits, poor sleep patterns, stress and environmental pollution, Singh said.

He welcomed the ILBS effort to create a National Liver Biobank and stressed the need for affordable early diagnostic technologies, community-level screening tools and indigenous biomarkers.

## CBI arrests MES engineer after taking Rs 93,000 bribe

Bags 10 lakh cash from him during search

**NEW DELHI:** Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested MES (Military Engineering Services) Assistant Garrison Engineer KK Soni of Manali, Himachal Pradesh for allegedly taking bribe of Rs 93,000 from various contractors for clearing their bills.

According to the CBI, the case against the accused was filed on July 3, 2026 by one of the supervisor employed in one of the contractor firm who alleged that the accused had demanded Rs 93,000 bribe from him to clear his bill.

The CBI mentioned that the complainant had paid Rs 40,000 cash to the accused in his office on July 3 and was told to pay the remaining amount on the next day. The agency laid a trap for the accused on July 4 and caught him red-handed when he demanded 93,000 from the complainant and took 53,000 from him. It also recovered 40,000 cash from the accused which the complainant had given to him on July 3 during simultaneous searches in his house situated in

The agency laid a trap for the accused on July 4 and caught him red-handed when he demanded 93,000 from the complainant

MES area of Manali.

Meanwhile, the CBI also recovered one more cash of 10 lakh from the accused's house in Manali during searches.

The agency is currently looking into the possibility of recovering more cash from the accused and is verifying the sources of the money.

The accused has been arrested and will be produced before the Competent Court in Shimla on Sunday. Moreover, the CBI has said that it will probe further to ascertain whether the accused had taken any other bribes and the sources of the money recovered. MPOST



# Iran begins days-long funeral for late Supreme Leader Khamenei

## The funeral for Khamenei could provide a boost for country’s theocracy and its new supreme leader, his son Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei

**TEHRAN:** Hundreds of thousands of mourners began a days-long funeral Saturday for Iran’s late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, beating their chests in sorrow before the glass case containing his flag-draped coffin in Tehran and calling for revenge against Israel and the United States.

The funeral for Khamenei, who ruled Iran for decades before being killed at age 86 in a Feb. 28 airstrike in the opening moments of the Iran war, could provide a boost for the country’s theocracy and its new supreme leader, his son Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei.

Mourners wept at the sight of Khamenei’s coffin alongside those of his family members also killed in the airstrike, with some chanting: “Our word is one! Revenge! Revenge!” Some carried banners and flags, while billboards across the city bore Khamenei’s image. Crowds of men rhythmically beat their chests in mourning, a common practice at Shiite funerals.

### Coffins on display at the Grand Mosque

An outdoor stage set up at the Grand Mosalla resembled the stage where Khamenei once gave his speeches at a Husseiniyah at his compound in downtown Tehran. A chair



Mourners attend the start of the dayslong funeral ceremonies for slain Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and members of his family at the Imam Khomeini Mosalla Grand Mosque in Tehran, Iran on Saturday

like the one he once sat in while giving his sermons, complete with a microphone on a stand and a small table next to it. Just above it hung an image of the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini, who died in 1989.

Khomeini’s funeral saw chaotic scenes as millions thronged his mourning ceremony and trip to the cemetery. Khamenei’s death, only the second time Iran has lost a supreme leader since the 1979 Islamic Revolution, came months earlier and gave authorities more time to

prepare. On Saturday, volunteers sprayed cooling water on crowds in the summertime heat as stands outside offered food and drink. Men and women congregated separately inside the Grand Mosque after being checked by metal detectors and body searches. Police armed with assault rifles stood guard on surrounding streets. Many stayed outside in the street, lounging under the shade of trees, because the city had shut down.

The caskets of his dead

### Highlights

- » The caskets of his dead family members sat beneath Khamenei’s, which had his black turban atop it
- » The dead included the wife of Mojtaba Khamenei, whose appearance at funeral remained unclear
- » Iran chose July 4, the 250th anniversary of creation of the US, to begin funeral, though authorities did not acknowledge the timing.

family members sat beneath Khamenei’s, which had his black turban atop it, identifying him as a direct descendant of the Prophet Muhammad. The dead included the wife of Mojtaba Khamenei, whose possible appearance at the funeral remained unclear. He reportedly was wounded in the attack that killed his father.

### Funeral starts as the US marks its 250th anniversary

Iran chose July 4, the 250th anniversary of the creation of the US, to begin the funeral. While authorities did not

acknowledge the timing, crowds at the ceremony in Tehran chanted: “Death to America!” The refrain has been common in Iran since the 1979 Islamic Revolution, the US Embassy takeover and hostage crisis. They also cried: “Death to Israel!”

The American president was not forgotten in Tehran. In the crowd in the Grand Mosque, several mourners held a large flag that read: “#KillTrump.”

### Khamenei will be buried on Thursday in Mashhad

Khamenei’s body will be transported to cities in both Iran and neighbouring Iraq. Authorities have shut down streets, airspace and daily life for the mourning, which will end Thursday as he’s buried at the Imam Reza shrine in Mashhad, Khamenei’s place of birth.

Authorities offered no immediate attendance count for the event Saturday, which saw the crowds cycle in and out of the Grand Mosque and the surrounding streets. Other cities across Iran also held mourning ceremonies.

On Sunday, a prayer for the dead is planned at the Grand Mosque. On Monday, his body and those of his family will be taken through the streets of Tehran, which likely will draw large crowds.

AGENCIES

# Ukraine drones hit St Petersburg oil terminal in latest Russia attack

**MOSCOW:** A Ukrainian drone attack struck an oil terminal in St Petersburg on Saturday, Russian officials said, as Kyiv presses on with bombardment of Russia’s oil infrastructure.

Almost daily long-range attacks on Russian oil facilities have created a fuel crisis and heaped political pressure on the Kremlin as its all-out invasion of Ukraine stretches into its fifth year. Gov. Alexander Beglov said the city’s Kirovsky district on the Baltic Sea was hit. He also said that air defences shot down 72 Ukrainian drones across Russia’s second-largest city and the surrounding region.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy described the attack as part of Ukraine’s “long-range sanctions” against Russia. He said that Ukrainian forces also hit a military target on the island of Kronstadt, just off the coast of St Petersburg.

“The Ukrainian defence forces hit the port oil infrastructure, which earns money for the Russian war, and there were also hits on Kronstadt — an important military target,” he said in a post on Telegram.

St Petersburg’s Kirovsky district was previously hit in June, ahead of Russia’s flagship St Petersburg International Economic Forum.

The Crimean peninsula, which Russia annexed in 2014, has suffered particularly from heavy strikes, causing local authorities to suspend gasoline sales to civilians. A Ukrainian attack on Saturday killed one person and injured two more, including a 10-year-old child, the Moscow-installed Gov. Ser-



The First Deputy Chief of the General Staff of Russian Armed Forces Lt. Gen. Sergei Rudskoy holds a news briefing in Moscow on Saturday

gei Aksyonov said. Russian President Vladimir Putin has shrugged off Ukraine’s strikes on Russia’s energy facilities as “not critical,” and insisted the war will continue until his goals are met.

He has described the attacks on Russian energy as an effort by Ukraine to distract attention from its losses on the battlefield, although analysts say the advance of Russian forces has been stymied in recent months.

On Friday, Putin visited the Russian military headquarters directing the war in Ukraine and received a report on the capture of the city of Kostyantynivka, after weeks of intense street battles. He hailed it as a key step toward capturing the nearby cities of Sloviansk and Kramatorsk, the key remaining strongholds in the so-called “forest belt” of heavily fortified cities in the Donetsk region that remain in Ukraine’s hands.

The capture of Kostyantynivka, a big transport and industrial hub, is of “major

strategic importance,” Putin, clad in military fatigues, said in televised comments.

Zelenskyy denied that Russia took control of the city. “It is just another Russian lie, an attempt to generate some kind of a news story,” he wrote on social media Saturday. “If Kostyantynivka were under Russian control, then perhaps Putin would have no problem meeting me there to find a diplomatic way to finally end this war. But the fact is, he won’t cross the front line — reality is very different from Putin’s words.”

The border city of Belgorod, which Ukrainian drone strikes have also repeatedly targeted, was left almost completely without power on Saturday due to overnight attacks, local media reported.

Meanwhile, eight people were wounded after a Russian attack struck residential buildings in Ukraine’s southeastern region of Zaporizhzhia, including two children, local authorities said on Saturday.

AGENCIES

# Decision to resign intensely personal: Starmer

**LONDON:** Keir Starmer has spoken of his decision to resign as Labour Party leader and British Prime Minister as an “intensely personal” one, which he took with his wife and children at a family weekend away.

In his first interview since his Downing Street statement that fired the starting gun for a leadership election, Starmer told the BBC on Friday evening that he would complete his current term as a central London member of Parliament.

But, while on the backbenches of Parliament, the

63-year-old politician plans on “keeping his mouth shut” to allow his successor — widely expected to be former Greater Manchester Mayor Andy Burnham — to get on with the job.

“I grappled with what was the best thing to do for me, for the country, for the government,” said Starmer.

“In the end it became an intensely personal decision. And that’s why it was a decision taken ultimately when (my wife) Vic and I were away with the kids,” he said.

The weekend before June 22, when he announced his resignation on the steps of 10 Downing Street in London, the Starmer family was at Chequers — the UK PM’s countryside retreat in Buckinghamshire.

“We just spent two days together as a family and that’s when I came to my final decision... Taking the decision that



Keir Starmer

your political career is over, it is an intensely personal matter, or at least it was for me,” he shared.

In the interview which marks exactly two years since he won Labour a landslide general election victory, Starmer cautioned his successor that they would be faced with similar global challenges that he had been consumed by during his truncated tenure as PM.

“Whoever is my successor, is going to face the same global conflict. We keep saying, and

it’s true, we’re in a more dangerous and volatile world than we’ve been in for probably most of my lifetime. That’s not just a phrase, that’s reality.

“That’s not going to change. And the domestic challenges aren’t going to change,” he said.

Despite being shunted out of office by what was effectively an internal coup, Starmer insisted he “never had any personal animosity” towards Andy Burnham and would “do everything I possibly can to make sure” that the next government succeeds.

“(I will be) keeping my mouth shut, rather than giving constant advice to my successor about what they should be doing,” he stated. The caretaker PM also highlighted that his four years as Labour leader in Opposition prior to winning the July 2024 general election were “absolutely core” to his legacy.

AGENCIES

### EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tender Notice No.: RTTM\_Upgrade/15.T.Exp., 2025, Date: 02.07.2026

On line (through e-tendering) Tender for the following work is invited by Dy. Chief Engineer (Track Machine), Plant Depot, East Central Railway, DDU for and on behalf of the President of India, from reputed Firms. E-Tender Closing Date: 24.07.2026

1. Name of the work with its Location: RTTM\_Upgrade/15.T.Exp., 2025- Technical Upgrade of 09-3X Tamping Express machine No. 3956 to latest available High Output Tamping & Stabilizing Machine (Model 09-3X Dynamic Tamping Express). Tender Cost - Nil. 2. Approx cost of the work: ₹ 15.81,20,000/- 3. Earnest Money: ₹ 31,62,400/- 4. Date and time for submission of e-tender: 24.07.2026 upto 15.00 hrs., 5. Website particulars of e-tendering: www.iireps.gov.in

Dy. Chief Engineer/TMC, Plant Depot/ ECR/PL Deen Dayal Upadhyaya PR/049/Plant Depot, DDU/MECH/IT/26-27/32

### WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY OPEN TENDERS

E-Tenders are invited on behalf of the President of India acting through Sr. Divisional Engineer (Co-ordination), Divisional Railway Manager (Works), West Central Railway, Jabalpur for the following works: (1) NIT No.: DRMW-JBP-112-2026, Dated: 01/07/2026 Name of Work with Location: Improvement and upkeep of track structure in Bina-Katni section under Senior Divisional Engineer (West) Jabalpur jurisdiction. Approx. cost of the work: ₹ 2,57,79,561/- Earnest money: ₹ 5,15,600/- Completion Period: 12 Months (2) NIT No.: DRMW-JBP-113-2026, Dated: 01/07/2026 Name of Work with Location: Welding of 60Kg/90T/S/R260 rails in-situ with single shot crucible fitted in connection with various track renewal works under Senior Divisional Engineer (North) Jabalpur section. Approx. cost of the work: ₹ 1,07,38,981/- Earnest money: ₹ 2,14,800/- Completion Period: 12 months (3) NIT No.: DRMW-JBP-114-2026, Dated: 01/07/2026 Name of Work with Location: Katni - Manikpur & Jukehi-Kymore- Provision of toilet and drinking water arrangement at level crossing gates. Approx. cost of the work: ₹ 65,64,331/- Earnest money: ₹ 1,31,300/- Completion Period: 12 months Last date & Time for submission of tender (upto 15.00 Hrs. on): Tender No. 1,2,3: 28.07.2026 Tender to be opened at 15.15 hrs on: Tender No. 1,2,3: 28.07.2026. Complete information of the above E-tender is available on website <https://iireps.gov.in> and also pinned on the notice board of the Divisional Railway Manager (Works) office of West Central Railway, Jabalpur. Tenders other than in the form of e-bids shall not be accepted against above tenders.

(SD) Divisional Railway Manager (Works) WCR, Jabalpur

# Germany’s far-right AfD party elects leaders as protesters, police clash

**ERFURT (Germany):** Delegates at the national convention of Germany’s far-right Alternative for Germany party on Saturday overwhelmingly re-elected its leaders, including the popular but controversial Alice Weidel, as tens of thousands of protesters aimed to disrupt the meeting, and some clashed with police.

Alternative for Germany, or AfD, met in the eastern city of Erfurt to elect its leaders, which German parties do every two

years. The party sought to show unity as it voted to extend the terms of Weidel and Tino Chrupalla, who have headed AfD for four years as co-leaders and ran unopposed Saturday. Weidel was re-elected with 81 per cent of the vote, while Chrupalla earned 70 per cent.

The demonstrations reflected how AfD has divided Germany even while becoming the biggest opposition party nationally and the strongest political



force in Germany’s formerly communist east.

Saturday’s event was able to start on time despite the pro-

tests, which party officials hailed as their “fundamental, legally guaranteed right to hold party conventions.”

“There are no peaceful seated blockades. There are no democratic roadblocks. Nor are there any gangs of thugs who deserve the harmless label civil society,” These troublemakers are the last resort of our political rivals,” Chrupalla said.

The weekend convention drew additional controversy by coinciding with the 100-

year anniversary of a Nazi Party meeting held nearby that consolidated Adolf Hitler’s power over the fascist movement. Historians and political opponents say the timing carries powerful symbolism, an accusation the AfD rejects. AfD achieved second place in the February 2025 national election with 20.8 per cent of the vote, the best showing by a far-right party since World War II. Since then, support has risen to first among the nation’s political parties.

AGENCIES

# Police probe shopping mall shooting that left two dead in Detroit

**DEARBORN:** A shooting altercation between two groups of young people at a shopping mall in Dearborn, Michigan, left two people dead and a third injured Friday, police said.

The shooting at Fairlane Town Center sent mall patrons scrambling, including a person who was hit by a vehicle outside the mall while attempting to flee, Dearborn Police Chief Issa Shahin said. People believed to be linked to the fight were being questioned at the police station, but no one was immediately taken into custody, he said.

Shahin said the altercation was not a random act. The two groups knew each other and after they came into contact at the mall a fight started that escalated into gunfire. Members of both groups had handguns, he said.

One of the victims died inside Fairlane Town Center and the other died at a nearby hospital. Details on the third person who was shot were not released. The mall was evacuated after the shooting and police planned to keep it closed while they investigated.

AGENCIES

# Fireworks, heat wave & politics: America celebrates 250th independence anniversary

*The signing of the Declaration of Independence, one of history’s most celebrated articulations of democratic ambitions, is being marked in myriad ways*

**WASHINGTON:** The 250th anniversary of American independence is colliding with a country gripped by political polarisation and a heat wave bearing down on millions of people across multiple states as celebrations get underway across the US on Saturday.

The signing of the Declaration of Independence, one of history’s most celebrated articulations of democratic ambitions, is being marked in myriad ways. President Donald Trump, set to take a central role in festivities, plans to speak on the National Mall in Washington ahead of what’s being billed as a historically enormous fireworks show that will rain down over the nation’s capital.

The president was in South Dakota at Mount Rushmore on Friday, where he delivered a dark speech about the threat of com-



munism in the US as the chiselled images of four of his most prominent predecessors loomed behind him. Elsewhere, fireworks are sched-

uled to be set off Saturday over Navy Pier in Chicago and against the skyline of New York City, which also hosted a ball drop at midnight to

usher in the holiday with the same fanfare as New Year’s Eve. Bristol, Rhode Island, describes itself as the home of the nation’s oldest Independence Day celebrations, dating to 1785. In Los Angeles, Queen Latifah will host a concert featuring performances by The Smashing Pumpkins and Chris Stapleton. Chaka Khan is billed as a special guest.

Anticipation for the milestone holiday has been building for much of the year, serving as an opportunity for Americans to reflect on their complicated history as onetime colonists of an empire who became a superpower of their own.

Celebrations months in the making had to adjust or cancel activities entirely as much of the East Coast sweltered under heat that approached and in many cases surpassed triple digits.

AGENCIES



**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

Letter No. DRM/C/AGRA/PARKING/E-AUCTION/2026      Date- 03.07.2026

**E-Auction Notice**

On behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway- Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-

Category: Parking    e-Auction Catalogue No.: PARKING-AGRA-AF

**Asset Details:-** Agra Fort. Railway Station, Agra Fort (AF) Station Daresi Side- Circulating Area- Mixed (Two Wheelers and Four Wheelers) Parking.

**E-Auction Start Date and Time:** Date- 20.07.2026 Time:- 12.00

**E-Auction End Date and Time:** Date- 20.07.2026 Time:- 12.30

**Note:-** Prospective bidders are requested to visit e-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number.      1529/26 FA

 North central railways     @CPRONCR     www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED**  
(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Ruby S/o Sh. Shailendra Kumar R/o H.No.1003, 12 Gaj TC Camp Raghubir Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 172/2022 U/s 160 IPC at PS: Tilak Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ruby** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ruby** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant), Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ruby of FIR No. 172/2022 U/s 160 IPC of PS: Tilak Nagar, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 21.08.2026.**  

**By order**  
**Sh. Vikas Madaan**  
**Judicial Magistrate First Class-07**  
**West Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi**

DP/9157/WD/2026

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 82 Cr.P.C.**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Robert @ Ravi @ Ganja S/o Joseph R/o H. No. 80, Janta Bihar Kali Piao, Najafgarh, Delhi.** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 37174/2017 U/s 379/411/482/34 IPC PS: Bawana Delhi.** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Robert @ Ravi @ Ganja** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Robert @ Ravi @ Ganja** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).  
Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Robert @ Ravi @ Ganja** accused of **FIR No. 37174/2017 U/s 379/411/482/34 IPC PS: Bawana Delhi.** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.08.2026.**  

**By Order**  
**Ms. Bharti Beniwal**  
**DP/8996/ON/2026**      **JMFC-05, Room No. 114, 1st Floor**  
**(Court Matter)**      **Rohini Court, Delhi**

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**(See Section 82 Cr. PC. /84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Braj Mohan, S/o Meva Lal R/o Jhuggi No. N-15/B-69, Indra Vikas Colony, Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi and Permanent Address Madanpur, Fejal Nagar, Grant Kher (UP)** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.541/2022 and 562/2022 u/s 129/55 DPG, P.S. Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Braj Mohan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Braj Mohan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).  
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Braj Mohan of FIR No.541/2022 and 562/2022 u/s 129/55 DPG, P.S. Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.08.2026.**  

**By Order**  
**Ms. Amardeep Kaur**  
**Ld. Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate, (North)**  
**DP/9060/NW/2026**      **Room No.117, Rohini Courts, Delhi**

**MODERN COACH FACTORY, RAEBARELI**

**E-Advertised Tender Notice No.: 16/ET/2026 Dated: 01.07.2026**

| SN | Tender No. | Short Description                                                                                                                                                                                          | Qty.        | Due Date   |
|----|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|------------|
| 01 | 12261088   | Standardized Brake Disc for LHB Coaches                                                                                                                                                                    | 9317 Nos.   | 24.07.2026 |
| 02 | 13251155D  | Nyloc Nut M6 Stainless Steel                                                                                                                                                                               | 951638 Nos. | 24.07.2026 |
|    |            | Nyloc Nut M10 Stainless Steel                                                                                                                                                                              | 1070404 Nos |            |
| 03 | 05261181   | Complete Design, Supply, Installation, Commissioning, Maintenance Manuals, Spares & Maintenance Work During Warranty Period & CAMC of Onboard Condition Monitoring System (OBCMS) For Vande Bharat Coaches | 144 Set     | 28.07.2026 |
| 04 | 05261190   | 9 KVA 750V/ 415V/ 190V AC 3 Phase, Dry Type Distribution Transformer                                                                                                                                       | 364 Set     | 20.07.2026 |
| 05 | 12241457A  | Kit of Rubber Metal Bonded Item for Air Spring Type Flat Bogie                                                                                                                                             | 1186 Set    | 28.07.2026 |
| 06 | 07261439   | Copper coated Co2 welding filler Solid Wire Size 1.2 MM                                                                                                                                                    | 200775 Kgs  | 30.07.2026 |

**Corrigendum**  
01    13 ET/2026 Dated : 12.06.2026      Tender No. **03261140**      Due date may be read as 07.07.2026 instead of 30.06.2026  
Website Address: [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) & [www.mcf.indianrailways.gov.in](http://www.mcf.indianrailways.gov.in)  
By, **Chief Material Manager/Fur**  
On behalf of President of India, Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Production, Modern Coach Factory, Raebareli is inviting open tender (No. MCFRBL-DyCEE-P-2026-27-03, Date-02.07.2026) based on **Single Packet system** online through Indian Railway Portal [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) for the under mentioned work on prescribed tender format. **Description of work:** Complete wiring work including handling & installation of equipments in LHB Non-Ac/Amrit Bharat (LWSCN-AB, LWS-AB and LSLRD-AB) coaches as per scope of work at MCF/RBL. **Approx. Value (in Rs.):** ₹1,35,41,970/- (Rupees One Crore Thirty Five Lakh Forty One Thousand Nine Hundred and Seventy only) including GST @18% **EMD (Rs.):** ₹2,70,800.00 (Rupees Two Lakh Seventy Thousand Eight Hundred only). **Cost of Tender document (Rs.):** 0.00 (Zero only). **Quantity of work** - 72 Nos. LWSCN-AB, 49 Nos. LWS-AB and 14 Nos. LSLRD-AB Coaches. **Work Completion period:** Eighteen (18) months.  
• E-Tender submitted through online up to 15:00 hrs. on 24.07.2026. Manual offer will not be considered. • E-Tender shall be opened on 24.07.2026 after 15:00 hrs. through online on <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. • Detailed Tender E-Notice and Terms & conditions are available at Indian Railway IREPS website: <http://www.ireps.gov.in>.  
By, **Chief Electrical Engineer/Production**  
On behalf of President of India, Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer/FP, Modern Coach Factory, Raebareli is inviting open tender (Tender Notice No. M-200/IN House Mfg. S&B/Amrit Bharat / MEMU/2026-27, Date: 29.06.2026) based on single packet system online through Indian Railway portal [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) for following work:- **Description of work:** Works contract for the work of in-house manufacturing of seat & berth for Amrit Bharat and MEMU coaches as per scope of work. **Approx. Value of work (Rs.):** ₹1,63,53,620.00 **Earnest Money Deposit-** ₹3,27,100.00 **Quantity of work** - 1. LWSCN (Amrit Bharat) = 72 coach set. 2. LWS (Amrit Bharat) = 49 coach set. 3. MEMU coaches (DMC/DMC2/DMC) = 27 coach set. 4. MEMU coaches (TC) = 81 coach set. **Work Completion period:** 12 months  
• Tender submitted through online up to 15:00 hrs. on 21.07.2026 which will be opened after 15:00 hrs. through online on <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. Manual offer will not be considered. • Detailed Tender Notice and Terms & conditions are available at Indian Railway IREPS website: <http://www.ireps.gov.in>.  
By, **Chief Mech. Engineer/ FP**  
Website Address: [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) & [www.mcf.indianrailways.gov.in](http://www.mcf.indianrailways.gov.in)  
**SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE**

**NORTHERN RAILWAY**  
**TENDER NOTICE**  
The Dy. Chief Engineer/Const., Northern Railway, Shakurbasti, Delhi for and on behalf of the President of India invites **e-tender** under **two Packet System** for the under noted work:-

|                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Name of work and location                                   | Construction of washable aprons, OH tank, UG tank, RO, pump room, water supply pipe line Automatic Waste Water Recycle Plant (AWWRP) with connectivity main road and other allied works in c/w Coaching Terminal MG area Shakurbasti. |
| 2. Completion period of the work                               | 09 (Nine Months)                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| 3. Approx. Cost of work                                        | ₹ 27.85 Cr.                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 4. Earnest Money amount (to be deposited Online)               | Rs. 55,70,000.00                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| 5. Sale /availability of tender document on Railway Website    | Tender documents will be available on IREPS web site i.e. <a href="http://www.ireps.gov.in">www.ireps.gov.in</a> from <b>14.07.2026 to 28.07.2026</b> upto 15.00 hrs.                                                                 |
| 6 Last date/Time of upload of tenders                          | <b>28.07.2026</b> upto 15.00 hrs. Tender documents can be uploaded by the tenderer on IREPS web site w.e.f. <b>14.07.2026 to 28.07.2026</b>                                                                                           |
| 7 Date & Time for submission of E-tender and opening of tender | <b>28.07.2026</b> at 15.00 hours (Immediately after closed of uploading of tender.                                                                                                                                                    |
| 8 Opening of tender                                            | <b>28.07.2026</b> at 15.00 hours (Immediately after closed of uploading of tender                                                                                                                                                     |

Tender Notice No.432-ACS-C-SSB Dated: 03.07.2026      2295/2026  
**SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE**

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 82 Cr.P.C.**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Sandeepa Singh W/o Sachin Lal D/o Manjit Singh R/o 102 Gali No. 4 Nirankari Colony Dr. Mukherjee Nagar New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Ct. Case/CC NI Act 1366/24 U/s 138 NI Act PS: Tilak Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sandeepa Singh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sandeepa Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).  
Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Sandeepa Singh** accused of **Ct. Case/CC NI Act 1366/24 U/s 138 NI Act PS: Tilak Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.08.2026.**  

**By Order**  
**Ms. Poonam Singh**  
**JMFC-04, Room No. 04**  
**Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi**

DP/9101/WD/2026  
(Court Matter)

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 82 Cr.P.C.**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Yogesh @ Mandi, S/o: Satveer Singh, R/o: House No.-J, Gali No.-7, Khadda Colony, Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 464/18, U/s 325/34 IPC, P.S.: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Yogesh @ Mandi** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Yogesh @ Mandi** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).  
Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Yogesh @ Mandi** accused of case **FIR No. 464/18, U/s 325/34 IPC, P.S.: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.08.2026.**  

**By Order**  
**Sh. Sahil Gupta**  
**Judicial Magistrate First Class - 07**  
**DP/8968/NW/2026**      **Court No. 6, Rohini Court, Delhi**  
**(Court Matter)**

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 84 BNSS**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Aashish S/o Naresh Kumar R/o D-5, Rampura, Manohar Park, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No.213/2019 US365/511/323 IPC, PS Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Aashish** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Aashish** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).  
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Aashish of FIR No. 213/2019 U/s 365/511/323 IPC, PS Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before **10:00 am** of the day of **05.08.2026.**  

**By Order**  
**Sh. Manuj Kaushal**  
**Judicial Magistrate First Class-03**  
**South East District**  
**DP/9095/SE/2026(Court Matter)**      **Saket Courts, New Delhi**

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 84 BNSS**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, **Shahdab, S/o Babu R/o H.No. 558, Gali No.8, New Mustafabad, Delhi,** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **eFIR No: 001129/2019, U/s: 411 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Kashmir Gate, Delhi,** and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Shahdab,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Shahdab,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person, **Shahdab, eFIR No: 001129/2019, U/s: 411 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Kashmir Gate, Delhi,** are required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.08.2026.**  

**By Order**  
**Sh. Vaibhav Garg**  
**Judicial Magistrate First Class-11,**  
**Central, Court No. 138, First Floor,**  
**Tis Hazari Court, Delhi**

DP/8280/N/2026  
(Court Matter)

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 82 Cr. P.C**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Sandeep S/o Sh. Tangraj, R/o: H.No. B-280 JJ Colony Inderpuri New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CR Case No. 440/21, FIR No. 343/20, U/S: 394/411/34 IPC, PS: Sunlight Colony, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Sandeep** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Sandeep** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Sandeep of CR Case No. 440/21, FIR No. 343/20, U/S: 394/411/34 IPC, PS: Sunlight Colony, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.08.2026.**  

**By Order**  
**Divyam Lila**  
**Judicial Magistrate First Class-07**  
**South East District Room No. 508**  
**Saket Court, New Delhi**

DP/9042/SE/2026  
(Court Matter)

**JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE**  
**DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU**  
**0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),**  
**email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in**

**LOOK OUT NOTICE**  
SP City North, Jammu vide communication No. SPCN/26/Rdr/14271-74 dated. 01.07.2026 has intimated that one un-known dead body was lying at mortuary room of GMCH, Jammu for identification. However, to ascertain the actual cause of death, Inquest proceedings U/S 194 BNSS, was initiated at P/S Bakshi Nagar vide DDR No. 10 dated 25.06.2026 and enquiry thereof started.  
For identification of said dead body wide publicity is required to be published on daily newspapers for identification / Public in general, having any clue related to the dead body. If any missing report is lodged, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact/Telephone numbers.  
**Description Roll:-**  
Age      65 years (Approx.)  
Complexion      Dark  
Height      5'03"  
Hair      White and Black Hair  
Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-  
1.DPO, Jammu :      0191-2547807, 0191-2561578  
2.SSP Jammu Mail I.D :      spsjammu@jkpolice.gov.in  
3.PCR Jammu :      0191-2542000  
4.SP City North      0191-2547038  
5.SDPO City West:      0191-2580251  
6.P/S Bakshi Nagar :      0191-2580102  

DP No:DP/J-5029/26      Sr. Superintendent of Police, Jammu

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Deepak S/o Man Singh R/o H.No. 92, Cigarette Wala Bagh, Model Town, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence case **FIR No. 01509/20 u/s 411 IPC at P.S. Mukherjee Nagar, Distt. North-West, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Deepak** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Deepak** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding **u/s 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita** has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Deepak** accused of **FIR No. 01509/20 u/s 411 IPC at P.S. Mukherjee Nagar, Distt. North-West, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **11.08.2026.**  

**By Order: Ms. Amardeep Kaur,**  
**Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate,**  
**North, Court No. 117,**  
**Rohini Courts, Delhi.**

DP/9053/NW/2026

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 82 Cr.P.C.**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Ashish S/o Ashok R/o N-15/152, Nirankari Colony Near Nirankari School Mukharjee Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **E-FIR No. 80059030/2024 U/s 411 IPC PS: Mukharjee Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ashish** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ashish** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).  
Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Ashish** accused of **E-FIR No. 80059030/2024 U/s 411 IPC PS: Mukharjee Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.08.2026.**  

**By Order**  
**Ms. Amardeep Kaur**  
**ACJM (N), Room No. 117**  
**Rohini Courts, Delhi**

DP/9056/NW/2026  
(Court Matter)

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023**  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Nasim @ Javed, S/o: Md. Tahir, R/o: H. No. K-113, Janta Colony, Welcome, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 531/2020, U/s 25/54/59 A ACT, P.S.: Welcome, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Nasim @ Javed** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Nasim @ Javed** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).  
Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Nasim @ Javed** accused of case **FIR No. 531/2020, U/s 25/54/59 A ACT, P.S.: Welcome, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.08.2026.**  

**By Order**  
**Ms. Deepakshi Rana**  
**Judicial Magistrate First Class - 03**  
**Court No. 19, Karkardooma Court, Delhi**

DP/9118/NE/2026  
(Court Matter)

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

**E-Tender No. PRYJ-Sig-020-2026-27      Dated: 03.07.2026**

**E-Tender Notice**  
Senior Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/Coordination/North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite **E-TENDER** on prescribed form for the following works up to **12:00 hrs.** on the opening date of E-tender mentioned therein. **The detail of the Tender is as under:-**  

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                        |                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>S. N. 1</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <b>Tender No.:</b> 020 | <b>Approx. Cost of work :</b> ₹ 65412493.43   |
| <b>Name of Work :</b> (A) S&T works in connection with modification of Prayagraj Chheoki, Link junction and Naini Jn. yard layout. (B) Signalling work in connection with Provision of a crossover for provision of simultaneous movement at Link Junction station.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                        |                                               |
| <b>Bid Security :</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | ₹ 13083300.00          | <b>Cost of Tender Form :</b> ₹ 0.00           |
| <b>Completion Period :</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | 12 Months              | <b>Date of Opening of tender :</b> 31.07.2026 |
| <b>2. Availability of tender form:</b> Tender forms are available on <a href="http://www.ireps.gov.in">www.ireps.gov.in</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                        |                                               |
| <b>3. Bid Security to be deposited :</b> The prescribed amount of Bid Security as mentioned above must be deposited along with the tender form Online through Internet Banking or Online Payment gateway only. The tenderer(s) should note that, in any case, the Bid Security in any other form than specified in GCC shall be acceptable. If the Bid Security deposited by the bidder is in shape of Bank Guarantee, it should be supported by proper stamp duty, rate prescribed as per section 13 & 24 of the UP Stamp Act, 2008 and amended from time to time at the time of submission of Bank Guarantee. Tenders without Bid Security shall be summarily rejected. |                        |                                               |
| <b>4. Time &amp; place of opening of tender :</b> Tender will be opened through E-tender at office of Divisional Railway Manager, Prayagraj at or after 12.30 hours. In case tender opening date happens to be holiday, Tenders will be opened on the next working day.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                        |                                               |
| <b>5. Validity of offer :</b> 60 days from the date of opening.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                        |                                               |
| <b>6. Right of Railway to deal with tender :</b> Railway administration reserves the rights to postpone/modify or to cancel the tender without assigning any reasons.      1519/26(DG)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                        |                                               |

 North central railways     @CPRONCR     www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

**NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY**

**E-TENDER NOTICE**  
On Line Single Bid based open E-Tenders are invited by Sr. D.M.E./EnHM. Frt. & DM/LJN, North Eastern Railway/ Lucknow for and on behalf of the President of India for the following works.  
**S.No.-1, Tender Notice No:** 03-2026-Mech-FRT-DM, Description of works: Repair, Maintenance and Housekeeping activity at Gonda Sickline & Freight Yard for two year." Approx Value (in Rs.): ₹ 7,06,84,393.41 Including GST, E.M.D. Money (in Rs.): ₹ 14,13,700/-. Contract period: 24 Months.  
• E-Tender can be uploaded by tenderer, up to 15:00 hrs. on 24-07-2026 and will be opened after 15:00 hrs. on 24-07-2026  
• Detailed information, minimum eligibility criteria, Terms and conditions regarding this e-tender are available at website [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) • Tenderer should check any correction/corrigendum related to this e-tender notice on website before uploading their offer.  
Sr. D.M.E./EnHM,Frt & DM/LJN, CPRO/Yantrik-47      Lucknow  
**Never travel on roof and foot boards.**

**COURT NOTICE**  
**(U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC)**  
**IN THE COURT OF**  
**Ms Jogindri**  
**Additional Civil Judge**  
**(Senior Division), Rewari**  
**Manohar Lal**  
**Vs.**  
**GENERAL PUBLIC**  
**CNR No. HRRE02-001436-2025**  
**Next Date 21-07-2026**  
**PUBLICATION ISSUED TO:**  
**GENERAL PUBLIC**  
**GP**  
In above titled case, the defendant(s)/respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on **21-07-2026 at 10:00 a.m.** For details login to <https://highcourthd.gov.in/3hrs> = district Notice & district = Rewari  

**Sd/- Ms Jogindri**  
**Additional Civil Judge**  
**(Senior Division),**  
**Rewari**

Date 03.07.2026

**UJVN Ltd.**  
(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprises)  
H.O. "UJJWAL" Maharani Bagh, GMS Road, Dehradun-248006  
Telephone-0135-2763508 Fax: 0135-2763508  
CIN No. U40101UR20015G025968 Website: [www.ujvnll.com](http://www.ujvnll.com)

**RO No. 550      TENDER NOTICE      Date: 04.07.2026**  
Office of the Executive Engineer, (M&G) Mohamadpur Power House, Gurukul Narsan, Haridwar invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:-  
**1. Tender No.:** 06/EE(MPH)/2026-27 – Hiring of One non AC (9+1 seater) Vehicle for School going Children and Power house/office works at Mohamadpur Power House for one year.  
**2. Tender No.:** 07/EE(MPH)/2026-27 – Hiring of one no. diesel vehicle (along with driver's services) for official use of Executive Engineer and one no. driver for running of departmental ambulance for a period of one year.  
**Estimated Cost:** Rs. 5,17,647.00 (GST extra) and Rs. 6,62,055.00 (GST extra) respectively.  
**Date of availability of bid document on website:** 05.07.2026  
**Last date for submission of tender:** 27.07.2026, up to 16:00 Hrs.  
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "[www.ujvnll.com](http://www.ujvnll.com)".  
**EXECUTIVE ENGINEER (M&G)**  
**"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"**

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED**  
(See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)  
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Sarik S/o Islamuddin R/o H.No. B-41, Abdul Fazal Enclave Jamia Nagar New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 291/2024 U/s 12/09/55 Gambling Act at P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrants of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sarik** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sarik** have absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant), Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sarik of FIR No. 291/2024 U/s 12/9/55 Gambling Act of P.S.: Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **14.08.2026.**  

**By order**  
**Manuj Kaushal**  
**Judicial Magistrate First Class-03**  
**South East District, Room No.512**  
**Saket Court, New Delhi**

DP/8977/SE/2026

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

**E-Tendering Tender Notice**  
Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line ( E-Tendering ) for the following work.  
**E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG - C- 2026-154**  
**Description of work :** Construction of road at AGD, JLN, BAB, & TBT stations under ADEN/LAR.  

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| <b>Approx Cost :</b> 20895637.35                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | <b>Earnest Money :</b> 417900.00 |
| <b>Date of completion /period from issue acceptance letter: 12 Months</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                  |
| <b>Date of closing Tender :</b> 03/08/2026 at 15:00 hrs., • Tender online can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs on 03.08.2026. • For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website <a href="http://www.ireps.gov.in">www.ireps.gov.in</a> 1515/26 (D) |                                  |

 North central railways     @CPRONCR     www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

**Tender Notice No.: 13-Elect/G/PRYJ/26-27      Dated: 02.07.2026**

**E-TENDER NOTICE**  
Senior Divl. Electrical Engineer/Gen/N.C.Rly/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to **15:00 hrs. on 27.07.2026.** The details of the tenders are as under:-  
**S. N. : 01      Tender No.:** ELG-33-2627  
**Name of Work:** Improvement of lighting in various staff and officers colonies over the Prayagraj Divn.  

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |             |                               |           |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|-------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>Cost of Work (In Rs.):</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | 20703875.20 | <b>Bid Security (In Rs.):</b> | 414100.00 |
| <b>Duration of completion :</b> 06 Month                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |             |                               |           |
| <b>S. N. : 02      Tender No.:</b> ELG-34-2627                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |             |                               |           |
| <b>Name of Work:</b> Electrical work in connection with the work of "Replacement of old FOB by 6.10M wide new FOB with Ramp for recoupment of Divyangjan Facility at Rura (RURA) station of PRYJ Division. Electrical work in connection with the work of "Provision of Ramp at FOB for divyangjan at BPU (Bhaupur) under CNB-TDL section." Electrical work in connection with the work of " Mattha Raising of platform no. 1 & 2 height upto High Level at Mattha station." |             |                               |           |
| <b>Cost of Work (In Rs.):</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | 9686047.27  | <b>Bid Security (In Rs.):</b> | 193700.00 |
| <b>Duration of completion :</b> 06 Month                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |             |                               |           |
| <b>S. N. : 03      Tender No.:</b> ELG-35-2627                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |             |                               |           |
| <b>Name of Work:</b> Provision of Modular switch, socket and boards arrangement with wiring in Type V and above officers Railway Qtrs. over Prayagraj division.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |             |                               |           |
| <b>Cost</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |             |                               |           |





## AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls commenced on June 25, 2026, across Punjab, where an Assembly election is scheduled in 2027. Significantly, on the previous day of the commencement of SIR in Punjab, a senior official from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) remarked that an Indian passport is “primarily a travel document” and should not be construed as definitive, standalone proof of citizenship. The passport debate got added significance as the border state has the highest passport density in the country. Thus, the document assumes significance as a token of a voter’s identity ‘as a citizen’ during the Election Commission’s (ECI) SIR exercise. Out of roughly two crore voters spread across Punjab, one-third, or about eight million, have a passport. This is nearly three times higher than the countrywide average of Indians holding a valid passport.

Within one year of the ECI’s SIR exercise, nearly six crore names have been deleted from the voters’ lists of nine States and three Union Territories. In June 2026, twenty-three Opposition parties sent a joint memorandum to the Chief Justice of India, Justice Surya Kant, alleging “biased” conduct by the Election Commission, highlighting the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) carried out in States such as West Bengal and Bihar, as well as the ongoing exercise in other States.

The MEA’s announcement that an Indian passport is “primarily a travel document” created a nationwide debate. The public reaction was immediate. Renowned screenwriter Javed Akhtar took to the internet to express the collective exasperation of millions, calling the statement flatly “absurd”. His logic was simple and unassailable: are authorities really issuing these highly secure documents to people without being completely convinced that they are Indian citizens, he asked?

Political leaders Kapil Sibal and Asaduddin Owaisi quickly pointed out the terrifying practical fallout, warning that if the country’s most vetted identity document cannot establish citizenship, ordinary Indians could face arbitrary challenges to their voting rights during routine electoral roll revisions. Terming this issue a ‘manufactured crisis’, Shashi Tharoor, a Member of Parliament, suggested that the government must undertake a pragmatic legislative update that aligns the law with the ground reality of its citizens.

The government quickly moved to defuse the panic, explaining that this wasn’t a

sudden policy shift but rather a long-standing legal reality. Officials pointed to Section 20 of the Passports Act, 1967, which gives the Central Government the rare power to issue a passport or travel document to a non-citizen if deemed necessary in the “public interest”. Historically, Tibetan refugees and Sri Lankan Tamils in India have been issued special travel documents by Indian authorities when visiting foreign countries. In 2023, the Madras High Court asked the government to grant a passport to a Sri Lankan Tamil refugee under Section 20 of the Passports Act.

## UNCERTAIN FUTURE OF THE DELETED/DOUBTFUL VOTERS

On June 24, 2025, ahead of the Assembly polls in Bihar, the Election Commission of India (ECI) initiated a pilot exercise—the Special Intensive Revision (SIR)—for updating the voters’ list. Following the Bihar SIR, the State’s voters’ list was pruned by nearly 65 lakh names amid allegations by the Opposition and activists that the poll authority was working at the behest of the BJP to disenfranchise citizens for want of documents.

After the successful completion of SIR in Bihar, Phase II, which began on November 4, covered over 51 crore electors across nine States—Chhattisgarh, Goa, Gujarat, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, and West Bengal—and three Union Territories—Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Lakshadweep, and Puducherry—spanning 321 districts and 1,843 Assembly Constituencies (ACs). Phase II of SIR ended with over 7.2 crore deletions across 12 States and three Union Territories. The deletions accounted for roughly 10.2 per cent of the voter base. Uttar Pradesh led with the highest number of deletions at 2.89 crore, followed by Tamil Nadu with 97 lakh and West Bengal with 90.8 lakh voters removed. However, nearly two crore electors were added through fresh registrations and address updates, partially

offsetting the deletions. After the revision, the total electorate across these regions stands at 45.8 crore.

Prior to SIR, the Assam Government created a National Register of Citizens (NRC) based on the Census of 1951. An updated NRC was published in 2019, for which links to the 1951 Register had to be established or legacy data with pre-1971 documents had to be provided by people to prove their Indian citizenship. The NRC was updated to ‘weed out’ illegal Muslim immigrants from Bangladesh. The Assam NRC excluded 19 lakh people, 14 lakh of whom were Bengali-speaking Hindus.

The system of marking people as “doubtful” by putting a “D” against their names in the electoral roll in Assam was devised in 1997, and it placed the “burden of proof” on the person concerned to establish whether they are an Indian citizen. Doubtful voters (D-voters), whose status as voters and as legal citizens of India is considered “doubtful” due to their inability to furnish proper documents substantiating their citizenship, constitute an exclusive category devised by the Election Commission of India (ECI) to single out those whose citizenship is under doubt. The ECI assigned the Border Police the role of referring these people to the Foreigners Tribunal (FT), where they are required to prove their citizenship before the cut-

off date of March 25, 1971, as per the Assam Accord of 1985.

In a case study on the lives of D-voters of Haripur and Amguri villages of Bongaigaon district in Assam, Nath and Parashar (EPW, April 2026) observe that, caught between the status of citizen and non-citizen, many of the D-voters in Assam face deep social, economic, and political marginalisation. They are forced to fight two battles simultaneously: one for daily survival and another legal struggle to prove their Indian citizenship.

It is reported that millions in India risk losing welfare benefits, including subsidised food rations and other State-run welfare schemes, over voter deletion. Even though the Supreme Court of India observed on May 27, 2026, that “...an exclusion from a voter list does not mean that a person loses citizenship,” West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, on Wednesday (July 1), said the State Government rejected around 26 lakh applications under the newly launched Annapurna Yojana after screening found the applicants’ names were missing from the electoral rolls. Claiming that “government money cannot be received by any non-Indian,” Adhikari alleged that the rejected applicants included non-Indians, deceased persons, individuals without voter ID cards, and those whose names appeared in multiple constituencies.

In addition to economic deprivation, deletion of names from the voter’s list can put any citizen in a “state of limbo” if he or she is caught between a pending electoral appeal before the Appellate Tribunal and a stalled passport renewal.

## INDIAN CITIZENSHIP — A THORNY ISSUE

After nearly eight decades since the adoption of the Constitution in 1949, India continues to struggle with a basic question: Who is an Indian citizen? Prime Minister Narendra Modi delivered a forceful warning against illegal immigration during the 79th Independence Day (August 15, 2025) address from the Red Fort, declaring that India would not allow outsiders to take the rightful place of the nation’s youth and daughters. He also announced a high-power demography initiative to address population dynamics and protect the rights of Indian residents.

The Citizenship Act, 1955, outlines the rules and regulations for acquiring and terminating Indian citizenship. The Act specifies five ways to acquire Indian citizenship: by Birth, Descent, Registration, Naturalisation, and Incorporation of Territory. However, the 1986 amendment to the Citizenship Act, initiated by the Rajiv Gandhi Government, states that, effective from July 1, 1987 (the date of enforcement of the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, 1986), every person born in India on or after January 26, 1950, but before the commencement of the amendment, and either of whose parents was a citizen of India at the time of his or her birth, shall be a citizen of India by Birth. This meant that if a child was born in India to parents who were not citizens of India at the time of birth, the child would not get Indian citizenship by Birth. Thus, the era of ‘stateless people’ began in India.

The 2003 amendment, introduced during the government led by Atal Bihari

THE WORLD’S LARGEST *democracy* STILL HAS NO SINGLE DOCUMENT UNIVERSALLY ACCEPTED AS CONCLUSIVE PROOF OF INDIAN CITIZENSHIP



Vajpayee, further restricted citizenship by Birth to a person born in India on or after the commencement of the Act, both of whose parents are citizens of India, or one of whose parents is a citizen of India and the other is not an illegal migrant at the time of his or her birth. The 2003 amendment introduced and defined the notion of an “illegal immigrant”, making illegal immigrants ineligible for citizenship by Registration or by Naturalisation. In 2003, rules were framed for the preparation of a National Register of Citizens (NRC), the issuance of national identity cards, and the maintenance of citizen records. In 2004, Section 14A was added to the Citizenship Act, making the registration of citizens and the issuance of national identity cards a legal obligation.

Soon after the Assam NRC was published, Parliament passed the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, 2019 (CAA), creating a pathway to citizenship for Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis, and Christians from Afghanistan, Bangladesh, and Pakistan who had entered India before December 31, 2014.

The world’s largest democracy still does not have a single document that can be accepted everywhere as conclusive proof of citizenship. Over the years, governments have issued ration cards, voter identity cards, PAN cards, passports, Aadhaar cards, driving licences, and numerous other documents. Yet there remains confusion over which document conclusively establishes citizenship. On June 30, the Gauhati High Court upheld a Foreigners Tribunal order declaring an Assam daily-wage labourer an illegal immigrant. Despite providing 15 documents, the court rejected the papers, highlighting the rigid evidentiary standards under Section 9 of the Foreigners Act, 1946. The petitioner’s documentation included copies of the 1951 National Register of Citizens (NRC) listing his father and grandparents, multiple voter lists dating back to 1966, a 2017 school certificate, a PAN card, and an Elector’s Photo Identity Card (EPIC). He also submitted oral testimony from his father to establish his lineage.

## WAY OUT

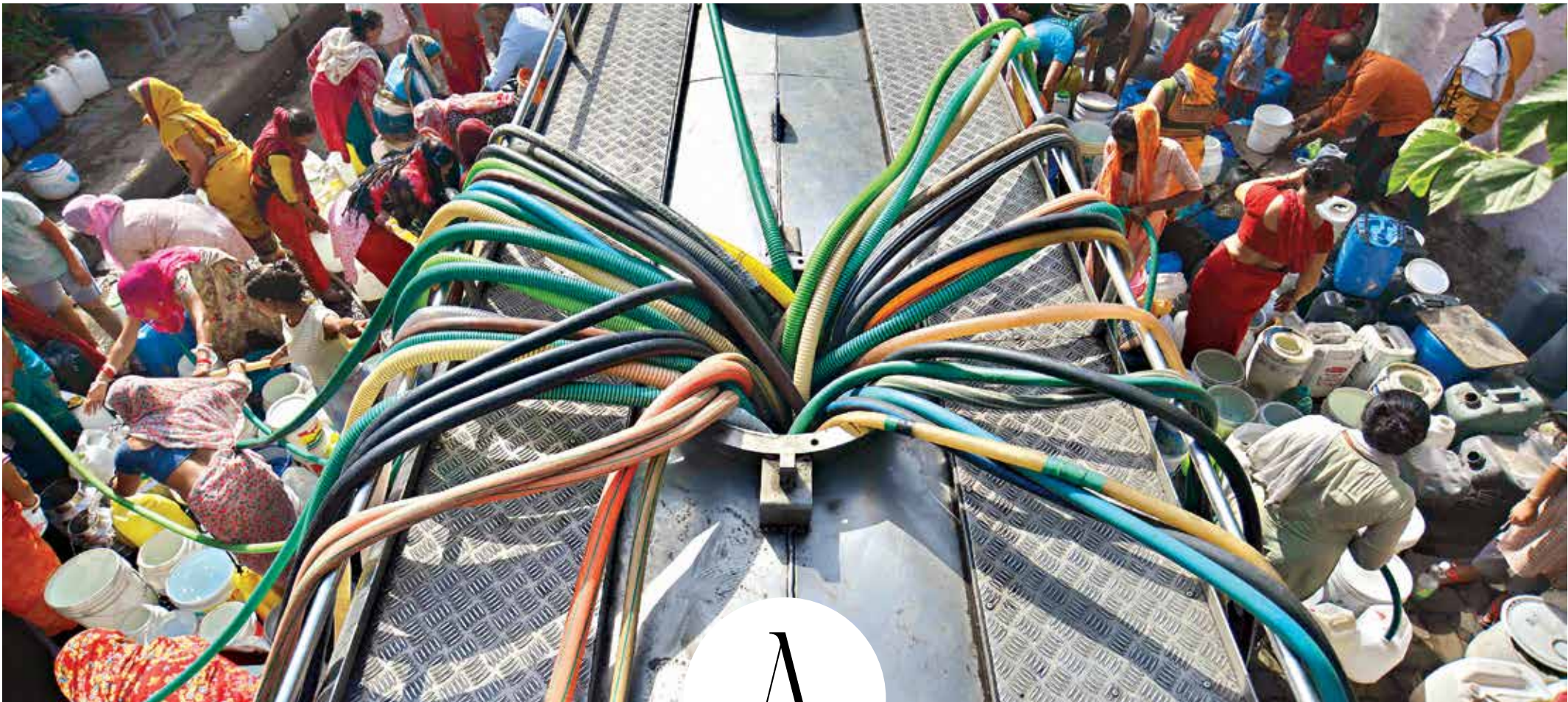
After the first two phases of SIR, deletions accounted for roughly 10.2 per cent of the voter base. If the same trend continues, then over 100 million voters (out of around 970 million registered voters in the 2024 General Election) may be deleted across India. In 2026, only 16 countries, including India, have populations exceeding 100 million. The question is: how will these huge numbers of deleted/doubtful voters prove their Indian citizenship?

Former Chief Election Commissioner S. Y. Quraishi suggested granting citizenship based on a birth certificate, as currently it is available to roughly 60 per cent to 65 per cent of the Indian population. The Registration of Births and Deaths Act was passed in 1969, making the birth certificate the foundation for all subsequent identity documents. In 2003, the NDA Government made birth registration explicitly compulsory and proposed a population register.

Article 15 of the 1948 Universal Declaration of Human Rights states: “Everyone has the right to a nationality. No one shall be arbitrarily deprived of his nationality nor denied the right to change his nationality.” The World Population Review says that in 2025 there were 75 countries with birthright citizenship, or jus soli, where the place of birth is the primary basis of citizenship. Recently, the US Supreme Court ruled that babies born in the United States have a constitutional right to citizenship, rejecting Donald Trump’s bid to end the 150-year-old policy. The United States has granted citizenship to everyone born in the country since 1868, with the right enshrined in the 14th Amendment to the US Constitution and bolstered by subsequent US Supreme Court rulings. India should also follow this globally accepted norm.

The writer can be reached on [drdipankardey1964@gmail.com](mailto:drdipankardey1964@gmail.com)





# A City Running Dry

*Delhi's water crisis now extends beyond shortages, with ageing infrastructure, contamination and distribution losses threatening the Capital's future security*

AIMAN FATIMA & ANAMTA FATIMA

Water has always shaped Delhi's growth, but keeping taps running in one of the world's fastest-growing megacities is becoming an increasingly complex challenge. As the capital's population crosses three crore and climate pressures intensify, the city's water infrastructure is being pushed to its limits. Rising demand, ageing pipelines, dependence on neighbouring states for raw water and mounting concerns over quality and distribution have turned water security into one of Delhi's biggest governance tests. Even as the Delhi Jal Board expands treatment capacity and modernises its network, ensuring an uninterrupted, equitable and sustainable supply remains a formidable task for the city.

WHEN DAILY LIFE FOLLOWS THE WATER SCHEDULE

Across Delhi, water availability continues to shape the daily lives of millions of residents. In several neighbourhoods, families organise household chores, work schedules and even sleep around the hours when water is expected to arrive. In colonies such as Tughlaqabad and Sangam Vihar, water is supplied on alternate days, often between midnight and the early hours of the morning. Missing the scheduled supply can mean waiting another two days, making storage essential.

Ruksar, a resident of Tughlaqabad, says her family of five relies on a 1,000-litre storage tank that must last for two days. During summer, the stored water becomes hot, forcing the family to use it sparingly. Buying water from private suppliers can cost around Rs.500 for a single supply, an expense many households cannot afford.

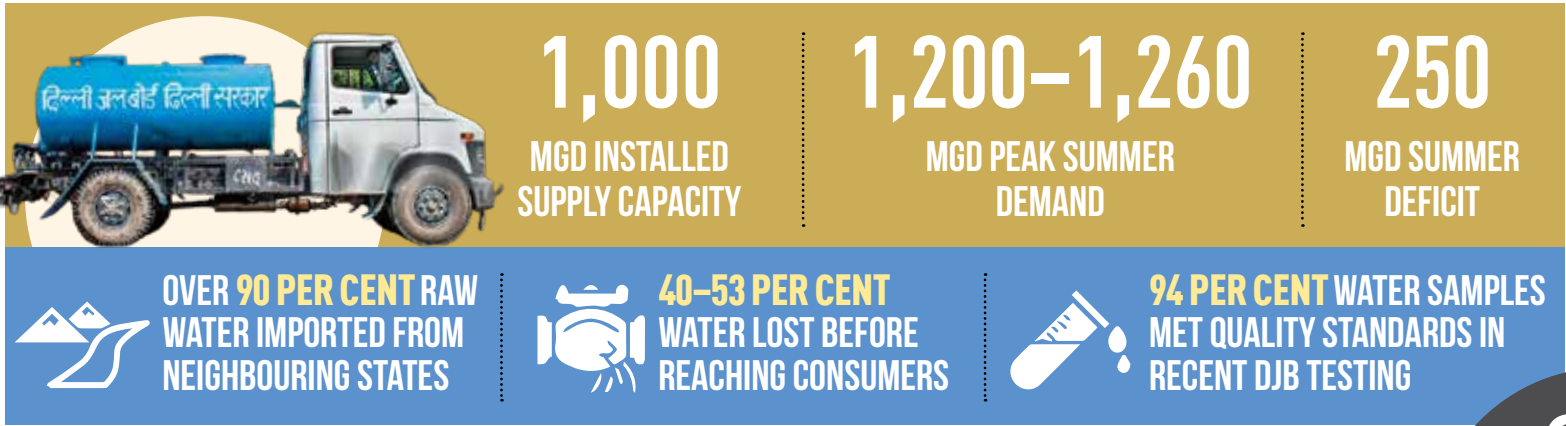
Another resident says the family keeps multiple alarms through the night to ensure someone is awake to switch on the motor. "If we miss the supply, we have to wait for another cycle, so our routine revolves around the water schedule," the resident says.

In neighbouring Sangam Vihar, Rahul says irregular supply has affected even drinking water arrangements. "Installing an RO system is difficult because water comes only on alternate days. We often have to buy drinking water, and sometimes even that has an unpleasant smell," he says.

For residents of Wazirabad, the concern is increasingly about water quality rather than availability. Several residents say the water now often appears dirty or has an unpleasant smell, making them hesitant to use it even for household purposes. Reduced water pressure has also become a recurring problem, with some residents reporting that supply stops without warning, forcing families to wake during the night to store water. Complaints about tanker overcharging have also surfaced.

BEYOND SUPPLY: ENSURING EVERY DROP REACHES SAFELY

Delivering water to a city the size of Delhi does not end at treatment plants. Once treated, water travels through thousands of kilometres of pipelines,



making the distribution network as critical as treatment. This summer, residents across South, East and West Delhi reported foul-smelling, muddy and discoloured water. Even affluent neighbourhoods such as Gulmohar Park, Greater Kailash and Hauz Khas reported quality concerns, with some residents linking the supply to stomach and skin ailments. Complaints also came from Defence Colony, Abul Fazal Enclave and Ghazipur, where some residents even reported worms in the water.

DJB officials attribute most complaints to ageing pipelines rather than treatment failures. Officials said, "water pressure is often lowered during shortages to ensure supply reaches tail-end colonies, although they described pipeline replacement as the long-term solution."

Recent Delhi Jal Board surveillance suggests water quality remains satisfactory across most of the Capital while identifying pockets needing attention. Between June 11 and 23, the Office of the Director (T&QC), Water Works, Wazirabad tested 5,478 samples, of which 5,177 (over 94%) met prescribed standards. The remaining 301 samples (5.5%) were unsatisfactory, with repeated issues reported from parts of Greater Kailash, Okhla, Dwarka, Nangloi and Bhagirathi/TYR. Officials linked these mainly to distribution problems, including low residual chlorine, turbidity, muddy water and sewage contamination.

The scale of Delhi's ageing network is reflected in water losses. Government estimates indicate nearly 40% of treated water is lost through leakages, theft, unauthorised connections and old pipelines, while the CAG report on the AAP period estimated non-revenue water losses at 45-53%, far above the

global average of about 15%, and noted that nearly 30 lakh households still lack formal water connections.

MULTIPLE AGENCIES, ONE SHARED RESPONSIBILITY

Managing water quality in Delhi involves multiple agencies. While the DJB supplies water, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) monitors public health by regularly testing water samples to prevent diseases such as cholera, diarrhoea, dysentery, hepatitis A and typhoid. Officials said, "residual chlorine levels are routinely checked, and any contamination complaint is followed by immediate microbiological testing."

Recent complaints have been concentrated in parts of West and South Delhi. Investigation reports are shared with the Delhi Jal Board for corrective action." Officials stressed that close coordination between agencies is essential for resolving complaints quickly.

Within the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) area, the council distributes water but relies entirely on the Delhi Jal Board for bulk supply. In June, repairs, pipeline leakages and reduced inflow from the Hasanpur Underground Reservoir feeder line disrupted supply in Vinay Marg, Sarojini Nagar, South Avenue, Teen Murti Marg and nearby government residential areas. During these disruptions, NDMC operated its 24-hour control room, deployed water tankers and urged residents to conserve water until normal supply resumed.

LOOKING AHEAD: STRENGTHENING DELHI'S WATER INFRASTRUCTURE

Delhi's focus is increasingly shifting from crisis management to strengthening

long-term water infrastructure. Water Minister Parvesh Verma told Millennium Post that the current challenges stem from years of ageing infrastructure and underinvestment rather than a single season's crisis. "This is not a problem that developed overnight. Old pipelines, untreated sewage and years of inadequate maintenance have created today's situation. We have begun replacing damaged pipelines, plugging leakages, introducing GPS-enabled monitoring of water tankers and improving the overall distribution network," he said.

The Delhi government is preparing a comprehensive Water Master Plan to modernise the distribution network and reduce non-revenue water losses. Experts say even a modest reduction in such losses could substantially improve supply without developing new water sources.

To boost availability during peak demand, the DJB has approached the National Green Tribunal (NGT) for permission to operationalise more than 100 borewells along the Yamuna floodplains, expected to add 30-40 MGD. Simultaneously, officials are negotiating with neighbouring states for an additional 528 cusecs of raw water required to operate four upcoming treatment plants at Dwarka Phase-II, Chhatarpur, Iradat Nagar and Najafgarh.

Long-term projects are also being pursued. The Kishau Dam Project, recently reviewed at a meeting chaired by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, is expected to eventually supply around 372 MGD to Delhi. The proposed Giri River Project in Himachal Pradesh and the Lakhwar Dam Project in Uttarakhand are projected to contribute another 275 MGD and 216 MGD, respectively, helping meet the Capital's future water needs.

Meanwhile, the Delhi Jal Board plans to desilt the raw water pond at the Wazirabad Water Treatment Plant through a Rs.25-crore project. Removal of 3.63 lakh cubic metres of silt is expected to increase storage capacity by nearly 100 MGD, improving the plant's operational efficiency during periods of high demand.

BUILDING FOR THE FUTURE

While meeting Delhi's daily water demand remains an immediate priority, the DJB is also investing in long-term infrastructure to strengthen the city's water and wastewater systems. Officials say, "the focus is on expanding sewage treatment, improving sewer networks, reducing pollution in the Yamuna and increasing the reuse of treated water."

During the current financial year, the DJB completed the upgradation and capacity enhancement of 10 sewage treatment plants (STPs) at a cost of Rs.2,014.98 crore. The projects at Keshopur, Kondli, Rohini, Coronation Pillar, Narela, Yamuna Vihar, Najafgarh, Nilothi and Pappankalan upgraded 305 MGD of existing treatment capacity while adding another 70 MGD, enabling the city to treat more wastewater and comply with stricter environmental standards.

The government has also awarded 14 sewerage and treated-effluent projects worth Rs.498.68 crore. These include laying new sewer lines in Karawal Nagar, Hasanpur, Tajpur Khurd and Sangam Vihar, providing household

sewer connections, upgrading the Molar Band STP and expanding treated-water pipelines from the Yamuna Vihar plant.

Alongside new infrastructure, large-scale desilting of Delhi's 11,450-km sewer network is underway. Around Rs.200 crore has been allocated for trunk sewer cleaning through 30 packages, while 16 jetting-cum-suction machines, procured at a cost of Rs.18.6 crore, have been deployed to clean peripheral sewer lines. Officials say these measures will reduce sewer overflows, improve drainage and minimise contamination risks during the monsoon.

Work is also continuing on strengthening the Interceptor Sewer Project, designed to divert untreated sewage away from the Yamuna to treatment plants. While officials acknowledge that delays and incomplete works affected its performance in the past, they say future improvements will focus on better integration between sewer interception and treatment infrastructure.

MANAGING WATER MORE SUSTAINABLY

Experts say Delhi's long-term water security depends as much on managing existing resources as expanding infrastructure. Although the Capital imports over 90% of its water, it receives an average annual rainfall of 744.4 mm. A 100 mm rainfall event alone could conserve nearly 17,600 million gallons through effective rainwater harvesting, enough to meet almost 14 days of the city's demand. Yet, despite being part of Delhi's planning framework since 2001, implementation remains weak.

Groundwater also remains under pressure. According to the Central Ground Water Board, Delhi's groundwater extraction rate improved from 100.77% in 2024 to 92.1% in 2025, but aquifers continue to be stressed. A University of Delhi study cited in media reports found South Delhi lost nearly 97% of its wetlands between 1991 and 2021, while over 75% of the Yamuna floodplain's 9,700 hectares has been encroached upon, reducing groundwater recharge.

Wastewater reuse offers another opportunity. While Delhi has a sewage treatment capacity of around 794 MGD, only about 584 MGD is currently treated.

Officials and experts agree that Delhi's water future will depend on more than new infrastructure. Alongside projects such as the Kishau Dam, Giri River Project and Lakhwar Dam, reducing distribution losses, expanding rainwater harvesting, protecting wetlands and floodplains, increasing wastewater reuse and promoting responsible water use will be essential to securing the Capital's long-term water needs.

30  
LAKH HOUSEHOLDS  
STILL LACK  
FORMAL WATER  
CONNECTIONS



# Reading the Past Anew

*Romila Thapar's **Just Being** emerges as more than a memoir, offering an intimate exploration of history, dissent, pluralism and the enduring pursuit of truth*

## AUTHOR



SUBHORANJAN  
DASGUPTA

The horizons of History have to go beyond the here and now

— Romila Thapar

I took the firm resolve after reading the two monumental memoirs written by the two Olympians, Goethe and Rabindranath, that I would not pick up a third. *Poetry and Truth* (Goethe) and *Jibansmriti* (Rabindranath) were simply incomparable in style and substance, in the multiplicity of themes explored, in the interweaving of the personal and the social, and above all, in the enunciation of their identical aesthetic philosophy based on creative humanism.

I clung to my resolution for quite some years but then my mentor's *Memoir* appeared, Amartya Sen's *Home in the World* in 2021. I had to read it, 450 pages at a blitzkrieg pace. It was a different though exhilarating experience because Sen is a social scientist and philosopher, not a creative genius, like Goethe or Rabindranath.

Fortunately, I broke my resolve again two weeks ago when my close friend, Naveen Kishore, sent me the Grand Dame's exquisitely written *Just Being*. What an incredible profusion of themes she has covered in 700 pages, from her fervent recollection of her childhood in Lahore to her restless academic quest in England and then to her dedicated role as a teacher of history at JNU, and to so many more. Well, willnilly, I had to choose and I opted for the evitable – recalling her epistemic exploration of the nature of history. In other words, trying to read history with her and unravel her historiography, which is not overtly complex but multifaceted and irrevocably committed.

The historian Romila is devoted to poetry and, therefore, she depends on two of her favourite poets, Faiz Ahmed Faiz and T.S. Eliot, to articulate the first few digits of her scholarly engagement. From Faiz she has learnt that as a historian she has to speak, come what may, the indestructible truth. The poet decreed *Speak, that truth still lives/ Speak to whatever is to be said*. It is this dedication to unflinching truth quoted in the very beginning of the book that brings the poet and the historian indivisibly together. Further, it explains why



Romila is still waging her relentless battle against the crass falsification of history and dubious mythmaking in its name. So, that is the first ingredient of her historiography. I am reminded here inescapably of our remarkable poet Sankha Ghosh's firm declaration. "A poet has only one function to fulfil, speak the truth", and also Sir Jadunath Sarkar's outspoken obligation, "The one and only aim of the ideal historian is to seek and understand truth".

Romila Thapar then turns to T.S. Eliot to unearth the very essence of history, to discover the integral connection – often complex and concealed – between past, present and future. She recalls those unforgettable lines of the conservative, Anglican poet: *Time present and time past/Are both perhaps present in time future, And time future contained in time past*. (Burnt Norton / Four Quartets). Moreover, she preface these words with her own commentary: "The voice you hear in these pages is that of my limited reflections. Yet it is my voice. Through time, it evokes the past, touches on the present and hints at the future."

(Prologue, XIX)

The journey of historiography has just begun. Her next ambitious aim is not to treat her subject as an autonomous, isolated monad divorced from everything else but as a palpable experience embedded in other social sciences and, simultaneously, interwoven with creativity, archaeology and even anthropology. In short, her indelible stress is on the cross-weaving of different disciplines, with one illuminating the other ceaselessly. She emphasises the fruitfulness of this epistemic approach by saying, "the growing interaction of history with social sciences enlarged historical studies to way beyond the narrative of dynasties." (Page 241). Such bold interaction prompts fascinating queries: "Could the theories of explanation from the social sciences be applied to past societies? If early Vedic Society was that of agro-pastoralists, could studying the patterns of life of other agro-pastoralists help historians in investigating the life of the Rig Vedic cattle herders?" (Page 241)

An indefatigable examiner of monuments and temples, palaces and ruins,

FOR ROMILA  
THAPAR, HISTORY  
IS NOT MERELY THE  
STUDY OF THE PAST  
BUT AN ETHICAL  
COMMITMENT TO  
TRUTH

she forges an intrinsic link between history and archeology. Nevertheless, her historiography warns against the statist misuse of archaeology to sponsor divisive political agendas. Obviously, she employs the harshest expression to condemn such patently unhistoric schemes, "For me, the insistence of these established archaeologists working for government but refusing to object to the destruction of a historical monument

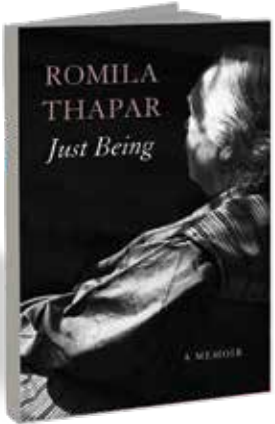
was the theatre of the absurd." (Page 413)

One just has to take a small step ahead from this terrain to arrive at the next indispensable milestone in her vision of history, namely dissent. We learn from her that disagreement, dispute – often acerbic, conflicts of thoughts advanced by different schools constitute the very lifebreath of history. That is why she details with infinite patience the acrimonious between Brahmanas and Shramanas and quotes Patanjali with happy conviction, "The relationship between the Brahmanas and Shramanas is as one between the snake and the mongoose." One has only to read her masterly *Voices of Dissent*, along with this Memoir, to comprehend the crucial worth of such combative differences.

Once we have resolutely posited dissent in its destined place in her historiography, her redemptive weltanschauung emerges spontaneously and we confront her multifaceted concepts of culture and civilisation, her very own theorems of reconciliatory nationalism and her ultimate ideology, which is not restricted to any specific doctrine but blessed by the invigorating principles of many. While her impassioned attachment to a pluralist culture and civilisation reveals itself when she affirms, "Cultures imbued with plural origins have to be nurtured... They cannot be reduced to a single strand emanating from those that wield power... now historians are viewing civilisation not as the culmination of a unique evolution but as the interaction of many cultures... Civilisations, therefore, are porous in terms of the societies they build and their interactions with others." (Page 698-699). Her sense of history seeks a resplendent summation in the faith, "I have all my life spoken and written in favour of a democratic, secular society and preferably broadly socialist in structure." (Page 689)

Yet, in spite of the crystal clear map she has drawn, she does not succumb to unreal fancies and indulgent dreams. Her corrective sense of history prompts her to say, "We still have a long way to go to become a practising democracy, despite our claim of adherence to the Constitution." (Page 689).

Dear teacher, dear historian, we remain fellow-travellers on this arduous path.



# The Many Lives of Rani Gaidinliu

*Som Kamei's meticulously researched biography restores Rani Gaidinliu to India's freedom narrative while examining tribal identity, Heraka, and unresolved Zeliangrong aspirations*

## AUTHOR



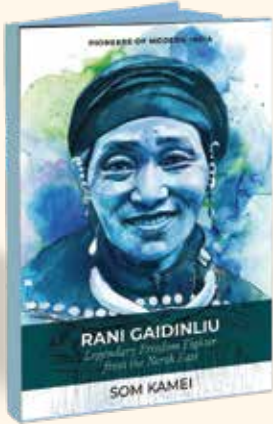
SANJEEV CHOPRA

indigenous faith traditions can be protected and preserved has not (yet) seen the light of the day.

This review is about Som's well-researched monograph Rani Gaidinliu: Legendary Freedom Fighter from the North East published by Niyogi Books, as part of their Pioneers of Modern India series. It offers a balanced perspective on one of the most remarkable yet frequently misconstrued figures of the Indian freedom struggle. Unfortunately, the resurrection of her memory is often juxtaposed against the majoritarian Naga narrative which considers Heraka – the back to the roots, socio-religious reform and indigenous faith movement of the 1920s – as anti-missionary and anti-Christian. Thus, the portrayal of Rani Gaidinliu (1915-1993) as a valiant anti-Imperialist freedom fighter who deserves national recognition is opposed by elements which owe their affiliation to one or the other underground factions of the National Socialist Council of Nagaland (NSCN).

Trained as a sociologist and an administrator, Kamei approaches his subject not merely through the lens of a standard chronological history of India's freedom movement, but also within the structural context of tribal identity, colonial policy, and internal community dynamics. He traces her trajectory from being a young girl in a remote village to becoming a formidable leader of the Zeliangrong Naga community.

The book begins with her cousin brother, Haipou Jadonang, who in 1926 established a religious reform movement aimed at consolidating the Zeliangrong identity to resist British colonial exactions of pothang bekari and pothang senkhai. The former was



the enforced house tax of Rs. 3 per month, even if one was unemployed; the latter mandated villagers to provide visiting officials with food and lodging and transport logistics.

Following her brother-mentor's execution by the British in 1931, the teenage Gaidinliu assumed both the spiritual and military mantle of Haipou Jadonang's Makam Gwangdi (Naga Raj) movement. Kamei captures the intensity of her guerrilla resistance against the British, her eventual capture in 1932, and her subsequent fourteen-year incarceration. A significant highlight is her intersection with mainstream nationalist politics, specifically when Jawaharlal Nehru met her in Shillong jail in 1937. It was he who first addressed her as the 'Rani' of her people, and attempted to secure her release. During his visit to Sylhet in December 1937, he wrote: "... six years ago, when the civil disobedience movement blazed over the length and breadth of the country, news of Gandhi and the Congress reached her in her hill abode, and found an

Honoured with the Tamra Patra, Padma Bhushan and several national awards, she remained committed throughout her life to preserving indigenous Naga traditions while advocating constitutional recognition for the Zeliangrong people

echo in her heart. She dreamt of freedom for her people and the ending of all restrictions they suffer from, she raised the banner of independence, and called her people to rally around it... and now she lies in some prison in Assam, wasting her bright young womanhood in dark cells and solitude... and India does not even know of this brave child of her hills, with pride. A day will come when India will remember her and cherish her, and bring her out of her prison cell."

Although by 1938, Assam had a Congress government under Gopinath Bordoloi, the Excluded Areas (to which Giandinliu belonged) were not under the jurisdiction of the provincial government. Nehru therefore wrote to an influential member of the British parliament, Lady Nancy Astor, to secure Rani's release. The Manipur Mahasabha (a Congress affiliate) also petitioned their Maharaja for the same – Rani had been born in Manipur – but to no avail.

Her jail term made her a polyglot: she could speak Manipuri, Assamese,

Khasi, Hindustani, Kachari (Bodo), Mizo and of course her own Naga language. Nehru was finally able to secure her release from the Tura jail in Assam in 1947, but as Manipur would not agree to have her back in the state for the next five years, she settled in Mokkokchung (then part of the Naga Hills district) with several restrictions on her movement. She did, however, start receiving recognition as a freedom fighter, a monthly pension of Rs 15 and security from Nagaland Police. Finally, when restrictions on her movement were lifted, she settled in Tamenglong in Manipur, which had a substantial Zeliangrong population, and then began her quest for a homeland movement.

According to Prof. Gangmumei Kamei, the decade from mid-fifties to mid-sixties marked three distinct, interrelated and to some extent, conflicting political pathways for the Rani and her followers. First, unlike the extreme radical Naga groups, the Rani participated in the national political process as it was necessary for the social and economic development of her people. She was also actively engaged in seeking a Zeliangrong homeland for strengthening the Zeliang identity (which was resisting the overarching trend of missionary proselytization), and she also identified herself as a proud Naga who supported a pan-Naga movement (with the caveat that the Zeliangrong would retain its distinct identity within the larger Naga spectrum). However, differences surfaced between the Zeliangrong supporters and members of the NNC when Heraka movement was criticised as anti-Christian.

After Nagaland achieved statehood, in 1963, CM Shilu Ao sought to bring her out of hiding. This task

was entrusted to a young IAS officer Subodh Chandra Dev, then posted as the ADC in the Zohengboto subdivision. Rani wanted to meet Dev without his security contingent: he agreed, and thus began a relationship of trust and affection in which he addressed her as mother. She told him, "For my people, I want no state, no country, but only a Zeliangrong district within any state of the Indian Union." She also clarified that she was not against Christianity, or for that matter any other faith, but as she said, "We are Nagas, and should live like Nagas. We have beautiful folklore and folk songs, colourful dresses and culture. When we see these new converts copying western ways in a cheap manner, it pains me." Dev also recalls her meeting with Prime Minister Indira Gandhi: "The PM stood draped all over with the colourful Zeliang(rong) attire and jewelry presented to her by the Rani" and "assured her that she would do everything possible to develop the Zeliangrong area as quickly as possible." However, even though the Rani was given the Tamra Patra Freedom Fighter Award in 1972, the Padma Bhushan in 1982 and the Vivekananda Seva Award in 1983 for her role in community service and the revival of indigenous tribal culture, alongside several assurances by Prime Ministers India Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi, VP Singh and Narasimha Rao, her quest for the Zeliangrong homeland remains unfulfilled. In her centenary year, Prime Minister Modi and Home Minister Rajnath Singh launched a one-hundred-rupee commemorative and a five-rupee circulation coin in honour of Rani Gaidinliu. Her legend grows, but the hope for a Zeliangrong Council continues to be a quest in the present continuous.





# God's Own Garage

*Kerala's car-modification culture is forcing India to confront an uncomfortable but pertinent question: Should automotive passion remain illegal by default?*

## AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

The first itch is never accidental. It begins innocently enough. A new set of alloy wheels. Slightly wider tyres. A throatier exhaust note. Perhaps a subtle ambient light package glowing like a nightclub trapped inside a dashboard. Then comes the engine remap. The spoiler. The suspension lift. The custom wrap. The bigger intercooler. The obsession. The craziness. Before long, the owner is no longer driving an aftermarket modified machine. He is piloting a personality. Welcome to Kerala – India's automotive mods underground.

No other Indian state understands the emotional heart-pull of auto modification the way Kerala does. In the narrow roads of Kochi, the hills of Wayanad, the highways cutting through Malappuram and the coastal stretches of Kozhikode, cars are rarely treated as devices for transportation. They are statements. Rolling biographies. Mechanical vanity projects. And sometimes, questionable aftermarket modifications.

### NEAT TWILIGHT MODS

For years, the mods culture existed in

a twilight zone. Kerala had India's most vibrant modification scene, but also the country's most vigilant enforcement ecosystem. The state's Motor Vehicles Department became both feared and meme-d. Social media filled with videos of highly-modded SUVs being stopped, fined or impounded. Enthusiasts viewed the traffic police less as a regulator and more as a heartless villain in their automotive soap opera. Yet, the truth was always more complicated than the Internet outrage.

Under Section 52 of India's Motor Vehicles Act and the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, structural alterations that change the fundamental characteristics of any vehicle are regulated. Engine swaps, chassis alterations, lighting upgrades and modifications affecting homologation are restricted. Courts, including the Supreme Court, have reinforced that no state can casually override centrally-approved vehicle specifications.

Which is why the new Kerala Government's recent order on modifications matters – not because it legalises automotive anarchy, but because it acknowledges reality.

### SMALL, BUT SIGNIFICANT

Leading up to the state elections, the United Democratic Front government had promised to legalise 'safe' modifications. Recently, it submitted a framework identifying 18 categories of alterations that may be permitted without special approval. These include accessories such as decals, ambient lighting, dash cameras, parking sensors, infotainment systems, roof carriers, TPMS units, reverse cameras and

limited sun films.

To hardcore enthusiasts, this may sound comically modest. Kerala's social media exploded with sarcasm after the announcement. Automobile enthusiasts and mod-firms users joked that the government had essentially "legalised floor mats and seat covers". But the significance lies elsewhere. For the first time in years, the conversation around modification is shifting from criminality to regulation.

That distinction matters enormously.

### CUSTOMIZATION CULTURE

That's because the mods economy has always existed in India. It is vast, cash-rich and totally unorganised. From aftermarket alloy manufacturers to ECU tuners, detailing studios, wrap specialists, suspension workshops and premium audio installers, thousands of livelihoods already depend on this ecosystem. Kerala merely became the first state politically willing to acknowledge this reality in public.

And why not? Across the world, customization is not viewed as deviance. It is culture. America built billion-dollar industries around muscle-car tuning and pickup personalization. Japan turned compact hatchbacks into expressions of mechanical art. Germany turned precision tuning into engineering prestige. Even South-East Asian nations like Thailand and Indonesia have thriving, regulated aftermarket industries.

India, for some reason, continues to behave as though changing a steering



THE OFFICIAL  
CONSENT FOR 'MODS'  
ACKNOWLEDGES THE  
*simple truth*  
THAT ENTHUSIASTS ARE NOT  
CRIMINALS AND PERSONALIZATION  
IS NOT THE KILLER OF ROAD  
SAFETY

wheel cover is the opening step towards societal annihilation.

### NEED TO BE WATCHFUL

Of course, there are some legitimate concerns. Badly-executed mods can kill. LED bars blind oncoming traffic. Poorly wired accessories can trigger electrical fires. Extreme suspension lifts alter vehicle dynamics. Fake performance parts sold without testing can compromise braking and stability. Kerala's court has raised alarm over

hazardous lighting systems, unsafe electrical installations and excessive modifications.

This is precisely why regulation is necessary, but blanket hostility should be out. Because enthusiasts are not going away. Today's car-owner wants participation, not passive ownership. Carmakers themselves encourage this psychology. Manufacturers advertise sporty body kits, adventure editions, connected-car technology and lifestyle accessories directly from factory showrooms. Instagram and YouTube have also transformed cars into content machines. An SUV today is no longer an SUV. It is a reel backdrop, a road-trip statement and, sometimes, even a substitute personality.

The slippery slope is real. Every enthusiast knows it.

### PITCH IS RISING TOO

One modification leads to another because the machine stops being generic. It becomes yours. The steering gets sharper. The stance is lower. The engine responds better. The cabin feels richer. Somewhere between practicality and irrationality, emotion wins. The owner is not just consuming engineering; he is creating it. That emotional dimension is something regulators have completely failed to understand.

India's auto laws were built around standardization, certification and enforcement. Those goals remain essential. But modern culture demands a more sophisticated framework; one that separates dangerous alterations from reliable personalization. Kerala may be nudging India into that

conversation.

The current framework is cautious. Rightly so. Major structural modifications still require approvals. Engine and chassis alterations remain controlled. Kerala itself has clarified that safety cannot be compromised. Yet, the symbolism matters. The state government has effectively recognised that customization, in itself, is not criminal behaviour.

### WILL THIS TRIGGER SENSE?

That could eventually open the doors to something larger – a certified aftermarket ecosystem. Imagine licensed modification workshops. State-approved performance parts. Standardised inspection systems. Insurance-linked certification. Tax-paying tuning shops operating transparently instead of in legal shadows. India's enormous youth demographic would embrace it instantly. Joyously.

For beneath the memes, the stickers and the booming subwoofers lies a deeper reality. The modification culture is about ownership in its purest form. In an age of algorithmic sameness and staleness, people want their machines to reflect individuality. Kerala simply said aloud what millions of enthusiasts quietly feel.

A car should not always remain exactly as it left the factory. Sometimes, it should evolve with its owner, like partners in any good relationship. Perhaps that is the road India must now decide whether to open, albeit cautiously, intelligently and safely. I say this door has to be opened regardless of all considerations.

## Game on



As the World Cup enters its defining phase, the tournament is increasingly becoming a story of leadership, pressure and players rising when nations need them most

## AUTHOR



S KANNAN

Pressure on marquee players during the FIFA World Cup is immense. It is not about individual goals; it is about scoring goals for their country. Two men from Europe who have attracted attention, aroused interest and instilled desire across continents are Kylian Mbappe and Harry Kane.

With football mania at a feverish pitch now, what can be said with certainty is that the success of the tournament is resounding. Forget the negativity that had engulfed

the showpiece event when it began last month. With three nations as co-hosts, it is heartening to see the United States of America, Canada and Mexico all make the grade for the last-16 stage. It tells you a story of how FIFA's choice of these countries to host matches was not arbitrary. The message is that football is also alive in these nations and they can produce quality talent. For Mexico, notably, it is a big thrust, having advanced this deep after a gap of 40 years.

Reactions to Mexico's win against Ecuador were ecstatic, as television broadcasts and videos on the internet captured the energy. By now, Raúl Jiménez and Julián Quiñones are well-known household names. How Mexico shape up against England next will be interesting. They are currently on a 12-match winning streak, and on July 5, England will challenge them. This is going to be an intense match, where Mexico have nothing to lose.

Just to jog the reader's memory,

England entered the World Cup with high hopes. A nation that boasts a robust domestic football league and offers riches to global players competing in it needed to come good during this World Cup. Against Congo, there was panic when England went a goal down early. What followed was magic from Harry Kane. Truly talismanic, the way the captain pumped in two goals has made Kane an even bigger hit.

As a football star in England, Kane commands massive attention. There is now a campaign in England asking whether Kane deserves to be knighted soon. The champion striker plays club football in Germany for Bayern Munich. More importantly for Harry Kane and England, he has been a stellar performer for the Three Lions in three successive editions of the World Cup. It all began in 2018, when Kane was named captain. He did not disappoint and went on to win the Golden Boot with six

goals. To say that Kane has grown in stature would be putting it mildly. He was captain again in 2022 in Qatar, where England reached the quarter-finals. Four years ago, the skipper also served brilliantly as a playmaker, and his assists were indeed valuable.

In 2026, when the whole of England needs its football team to fire, the man most looked up to is once again the skipper. Two brilliantly taken goals against Congo have shown how Harry Kane can deliver under pressure. He has already surpassed Gary Lineker as a legend; that is the unanimous view. More contemporarily, if comparisons are to be made, Kane has scored more goals for England than Wayne Rooney and Alan Shearer combined. For those who view football positively, Harry Kane's stature is immense.

England were under pressure against Congo. What was needed was one player to create space and score. Kane was breathtaking,

though England's former footballers, including the sulking Rooney, feel the Three Lions are still not doing well enough. In tight matches, what matters is breaking free and winning. Kane has shown he is in the zone and can score goals almost at will. Surely, at 32, Kane is thinking about Mexico. As a forward, Kane is a complete player. He strikes hard, runs well and possesses sharp passing skills. If needed, he can also drop deep to bolster the defence.

Constant media scrutiny and a personal life under the scanner — Harry Kane soaks up pressure like a sponge. This is his third World Cup and one can hardly find fault with him. What also comes across as pleasing is the respect captain Kane commands from his teammates and fans. He has been England's saviour till now.

At a time when sport in England craves heroes, football remains the nation's biggest hope. Men's cricket has been in the news for the wrong reasons, with Ben Stokes retiring abruptly just before the loss to New Zealand in the final Test at home last week. Football is a staple diet for Englishmen, much like beer and fish and chips at the pubs. Even as England stay afloat, so much rubbish has been written about Thomas Tuchel as manager. He hails from Germany but has been handling the key responsibility for England since 2025.

If Harry Kane has been sensational, Kylian Mbappe has been a delight. France have shown great potential and delivered in this World Cup. There is no doubt that France have played fluent football from the very first match. They have functioned smoothly

and earned lavish praise from all quarters. In their last match, thrashing Sweden 3-0 showed they are leaving nothing to chance. This has been a masterclass all the way till now.

Up next, France face Paraguay early on Sunday morning. Nobody expected Paraguay to come this far. But then, a side that knocked Germany out on penalties cannot be taken lightly. The football world has proclaimed that Germany are no longer the force they once were. There is truth in that statement, for the Germans have not been able to raise their level in recent editions of the World Cup. All the talk now is about how some European teams have lost their zing.

Geographically, Paraguay is a South American country. It shares borders with Argentina, Brazil and Bolivia. Their best run came in the 2010 World Cup, when they reached the quarter-finals. For a nation that is not spoken of as highly as some of the other teams from that region, they have overachieved this time. In fact, knocking out Germany is being rated as one of the biggest upsets in football history.

The big challenge is more for France, who have been well served by Mbappe. Prior to the World Cup, the Les Bleus star was under discussion because he had not done well at Real Madrid. Once the World Cup began, however, there were no question marks over Mbappe. He has been a class act, with the goals he has scored proving vital for France. Just 27 and full of energy, Mbappe burst into brilliance against Sweden. Commentators and writers are going gaga over what he has done in this World Cup, perhaps forgetting his previous exploits.

The talk now is about the

race for the Golden Boot, where Mbappe and Lionel Messi are locked in a battle. Messi is much older and is playing in his sixth World Cup. For Mbappe, the opportunity to stand up and be counted has become even more pronounced. If you look at history, Kylian Mbappe has had issues with the national side. This time, however, he is hungry and ready to strike a rapport with manager Didier Deschamps, who had to take a break owing to a personal loss recently. When Mbappe scored his first goal against Sweden, he looked towards Deschamps emotionally.

Then again, Mbappe has spoken about why he is doing well for France this time. "We are all together," said Mbappe in a recent interview. It means Mbappe is combining well with the other players in the French side — Ousmane Dembele and Michael Olise in particular. In 2018, when Mbappe broke into the French squad for the World Cup, he was just 19. Call it raw or fresh, he scored in the final as France emerged champions. In 2022, in Qatar, Mbappe was again on fire. That France lost the final to Argentina on penalties is something that will continue to drive him. He has to deliver to keep the flame burning for France in the 2026 World Cup.

Imagine, at such a young age, this French star, whose parents are from Cameroon and Algeria, has rocked the football world. People can rave about Messi. Yet, if you look at the shorter time span in comparison, Kylian Mbappe is sensational. The football he has produced till now in this World Cup has been energising and effective. The world watches the action in awe as the climax nears.





From one end of border politics angst to the other, the first six months of 2026 have shown that audiences are drawn to spectacle and high-octane nationalism but also to quieter storytelling

'DHURANDHAR 2', 'BORDER 2' AND 'MAIN VAAPAS AAUNGA'

Content is the absolute king

**D**hurandhar: 'The Revenge', 'Border 2' and then 'Main Vaapas Aaunga'. From one end of border politics angst to the other, the first six months of 2026 have shown that audiences are drawn to spectacle and high-octane nationalism but also to quieter storytelling.

More than two dozen films were released in theatres in the first half of the year. But three stood out - 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge', the second instalment in Aditya Dhar's espionage saga, grossed over Rs 1,800 crore worldwide, 'Border 2' came up second with Rs 450 crore and then there was 'Bhooth Bangla', which earned Rs 270 crore.



the content, they are in the mood to enjoy right now," Chauhan told PTI.

He also noted that the theatrical momentum was impacted by the temporary slowdown during the IPL season and the election period. The conflict in West Asia also led to the postponement of many films, he added.

"We had a slightly dull period between April and May because of the IPL and the elections, which were being held across the country. Also, filmmakers cancelled the release of films like 'Toxic' and Salman Khan's 'Maatrubhumi', which disrupted the calendar for the whole release schedule," Chauhan noted.

South Indian movies reflected a similar pattern of a few big successes amid a high volume of underperformers, with nearly 70 per cent of releases failing to make an impact, according to Chennai-based trade analyst Ramesh Bala.

Telugu movies such as Chiranjeevi's 'Mana Shankara Vara Prasad Garu' and Ram Charan's 'Peddi' both amassed over Rs 300 crores at the box office. In Tamil cinema, 'Karuppu' starring Suriya garnered over Rs 300 crore.

Bala said that in Malayalam, the coming-of-age comedy 'Vaazha 2' and Mohanlal's 'Drishyam 3' did business of over Rs. 240 crores.

"Usually, in the first six months, about 100 films would've been released here, out of which two or three would be blockbusters, five to six would be hit films and the rest would perform average or below average. But films that have not succeeded would be close to 70 per cent across all four South languages. Also, 'Maa Inti Bangaaram' in Telugu and 'Blast', a female action movie in Tamil, have done well," Bala told PTI.



Apart from them, only Shahid Kapoor-led 'O'Romeo' and 'Cocktail 2' crossed the Rs 100 crore milestone.

In June came Imtiaz Ali's partition saga 'Main Vaapas Aaunga', so different in tonality from 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge', which lived up to the massive expectations generated by the first film in December 2025 and 'Border 2', a sequel to the 1997 hit 'Border'. Pakistan is the leitmotif in all films, but the stories and the treatment differ widely.

"We've got three legitimate super hits: 'Dhurandhar 2', 'Border 2' and 'Bhooth Bangla'. The numbers we see are Rs 3,000 crore, but these numbers have come from three to four films and it could have been six to eight films. So, we've fewer successful films, but we're satisfactory box-office numbers," trade analyst Girish Wankhede told PTI.

He said the period was 'satisfactory but not extraordinary', with the silver lining being that successful films did bigger business.

Several highly anticipated titles, including Sriram Raghavan's 'Ikki', Varun Dhawan's 'Hai Jawani Toh Ishq Hona Hai', Ayushmann Khurrana's 'Pati Patni Aur Woh Do', Karan Johar's production 'Chand Mera Dil', underperformed, according to Wankhede.

"These highly anticipated films were expected to perform well, but they didn't," he said.

Kamal Gianchandani, chief business planning & strategy, PVR INOX Limited, added that films, big and small, with a 'big heart' garnered love from people. He gave the example of 'Main Vaapas Aaunga', which opened to positive reviews on June 12 but had a slow start at the box office.

However, strong word of mouth helped it gather momentum in its second week, prompting exhibitors and distributors to increase the number of shows across the country.

"Content is the king and the response to 'Main Vaapas Aaunga' is an example of that. If it is just scale and no content, then maybe people will come for the first weekend, but the excitement will reduce after that," Gianchandani told PTI.

He added, "If the film has content and scale, that's the ultimate thing. A movie like 'Dhurandhar' opened big and it kept getting bigger. But even if the content is there and the scale is small, even then people turn up in theatres because people want to be entertained, they want to cut off from their day-to-day life."

SOUTH INDIAN MOVIES REFLECTED A SIMILAR PATTERN OF A FEW BIG SUCCESSES AMID A HIGH VOLUME OF UNDERPERFORMERS

According to Gianchandani, the first six months of 2026 saw a 10 to 12 per cent rise in admissions and a 16 to 17 per cent increase in overall box office collection compared to the same period last year.

Bihar-based exhibitor and distributor Vishek Chauhan said the overall trend indicates strong audience intent, provided the content resonates with them.

"The first six months have been pretty decent. So, the good thing is that audiences are coming out in huge numbers and people are clearly giving us signals that they want to watch movies in theatres. If you give them

big-ticket releases failing to lure audiences in large numbers.

"Pongal releases like Siva-karthikeyan's 'Parasakthi', Karthi's 'Vaa Vaathiyaar' performed. 'Peddi' underperformed. Rather than doing Pan-India subjects, they should do rooted films that become big hits. For instance, Ram Charan's 'Rangasthalam' was a properly rooted Telugu commercial film and it was a blockbuster. If you notice, all Telugu heroes give one big hit and then want to go to Pan-India. Even if Prabhas does one proper Telugu film without worrying about pan-India (trappings), he can get a big opening at the box office," Mathivanan told PTI.

Looking ahead, industry experts remain optimistic about the second half of 2026, with a strong release slate like YRF's 'Alpha', Ajay Devgn's 'Dhamaal 4', Salman Khan's 'Maatrubhumi', Nitesh Tiwari-directed 'Ramayana', Shah Rukh Khan's 'King'.

They are also betting big and Hollywood movies like Christopher Nolan's 'The Odyssey' and Tom Holland-starrer 'Spider-Man: Brand New Day' as well as the next 'Marvel' tentpole 'Avengers: Doomsday'.

"The line-up is pretty exciting. The audience is willing to come when the product comes. So, the onus really lies upon the production and the creative side to make engaging enough products for the audiences to come and watch them in a theatre close by," Chauhan said.

In 2025, the first half was dominated by the success of Vicky Kaushal-led historical drama 'Chhava' that earned over Rs 600 crore. The overall collection during this period hovered around Rs 1,900 crore during the same period last year.

PTI

'Daemon' is most interesting when pushed to the edge'



'House of the Dragon' star Matt Smith isn't interested in defining Daemon Targaryen as either a villain or a hero

RAVI BANSAL

**H**ouse of the Dragon' star Matt Smith said he is not interested in defining Daemon Targaryen as either a villain or a hero and instead prefers to explore the darker edges of the character's personality.

Smith, the star of popular shows 'Doctor Who' and 'The Crown', returned as the fiercely ambitious and volatile Targaryen prince in the third season of the 'Game of Thrones' spin-off series, which is streaming on 'JioHotstar'.

The British actor said his aim with the character has always been to push the character as far as possible and see whether he can find a way back.

"It's quite an odd thing; an audience should look and judge and label. But to do it inside of it and to go, 'Well, is he a villain? Is he not a villain? Is he a hero? Is he an anti-hero?'" Smith told PTI in a virtual group interview.

The actor added, "My real main interest with him has been... let's get this character to be the worst ver-



sion of himself. Push him as far as you can towards the precipice, the edge of the cliff, the things that you think are impossible for a character to come back from. So, whether that makes him a villain or an anti-hero, I don't know. It's for other people to decipher. But I think that's where he's most interesting."

Based on parts of the 'Fire & Blood' novel by celebrated author George R R Martin, 'House of the Dragon' is set nearly 200 years before the events of

'Game of Thrones', the blockbuster series which ran for eight seasons on HBO from 2011 to 2019.

The prequel series chronicles the rise and fall of House Targaryen and centres on a bitter succession struggle

DAEMON TARGARYEN IS ONE OF THE MOST UNPREDICTABLE AND COMPELLING FIGURES IN THE SHOW

known as the Dance of the Dragons, a devastating civil war that pits rival factions of the ruling family against each other in a battle for the Iron Throne.

Smith's Daemon Targaryen, a skilled warrior and dragon-rider known for his charisma, impulsiveness and ruthless streak, is one of the most unpredictable and compelling figures in the show.

He is the younger brother of King Viserys I Targaryen and later the husband of Rhaenyra Targaryen, played by actress Emma D'Arcy.

Smith said he missed sharing the screen space with D'Arcy in the show's second season as their characters were based in different locations and had few scenes together.

"I was campaigning in season two to get back on the floor with Emma and with Daemon and Rhaenyra because, both from a character perspective, but also from an acting perspective and from a human perspective... My admiration knows no bounds,

really," he said.

He added, "What's been really amazing over the last four or five years is seeing Emma approach the craft and the journey of that in just the most incredible, detailed way. It's been something to behold."

Smith also spoke about his love for fantasy storytelling.

The actor said he enjoys genres such as magical realism and horror as a viewer and believes large-scale fantasy productions offer audiences a welcome escape.

"What I do as a punter and as a consumer, I love in literature. I love magic realism. The last couple of years of my life, I've got really into horror, like sort of consuming horror movies at every level as well. So, when it's done on scale, when this type of thing is done well, I think it's a good way to transport an audience out of their everyday lives into somewhere interesting for a couple of hours," he said.

Season three of 'House of the Dragon' also stars Steve Toussaint, Rhys Ifans, Fabien Frankel, Ewan Mitchell, Tom Glynn-Carney, Harry Collett, Bethany Antonia, Phoebe Campbell, James Norton, Tom Bennett, Freddie Fox, Clinton Liberty, Gayle Rankin, Abubakar Salim and Tom Cullen.